

The Quiet Hours

A Psychological Thriller with a Twist You Won't See Coming
by Digital Empire

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The Key I Don't Remember

The night shift starts at ten, and by ten past I already know how the next eight hours will go. Room 12 will ring twice before midnight. Mr. Aldridge in 7 will ask me what year it is and accept my answer with the polite disappointment of a man who was hoping for a different one. The vending machine on the second floor will eat someone's coins. Somewhere around three, the building will go so quiet I can hear the radiators thinking.

I like it. That's the part people don't understand when they hear *night nurse* and make a face. They picture loneliness. What I get is order. During the day, Ridgemont Care Home is chaos with a schedule taped over it: families, deliveries, physical therapists tracking rain across the linoleum. At night it becomes a machine with eleven moving parts, and I know all eleven by name.

Fourteen months ago I would have said I liked the day shift. Fourteen months ago I slept.

I hang my coat in the staff room and that's when I find it.

There's a key in my left pocket. Not my house key. That one lives on a ring with a plastic tag from a hotel in Brighton, a place I went once and never again. This is a single key, brass, cut square at the shoulder, with a stamped number on the bow: 47. It's cold, which means it's been in the pocket long enough to lose whatever warmth my body would have given it.

I hold it up to the light and wait for my brain to do the thing brains do, the small click of recognition. Nothing clicks.

"That's not mine," I say, out loud, to the staff room, which does not respond.

I go through the reasonable explanations because that's what you do. A patient handed it to me and I pocketed it without thinking. Possible, we're told to hand

found objects to the front desk, but possible. A colleague borrowed my coat. Nobody borrows my coat. It came with the coat. I've had this coat two winters.

There's a fourth explanation and I don't look at it directly, the way you don't look directly at the sun or at a bill you haven't opened. The fourth explanation is that I put it there.

I put the key on the shelf next to the kettle, where lost things go, and I go start my rounds.

The rounds are the same rounds. I want to describe them properly, because the ordinarieness matters, because everything that comes after has to be laid on top of eight hours of a job I have done four nights a week for eleven years and can do with my hands while my head is somewhere else entirely.

Room 3, Mrs. Duffy, hip replacement six weeks ago, sleeping on her back with her mouth open and one hand up by her ear like a child. Room 5, empty since Tuesday, stripped bed, and I still look in. Room 7, Mr. Aldridge, awake.

"What year is it?"

"It's 2026, love."

"Is it." He takes this the way he always takes it, with the small tired courtesy of a man who has been given a wrong answer by a competent person. "I thought it was earlier than that."

"You're not the only one."

Room 9, the Kelly sisters, who are not sisters and who have insisted on being roomed together for two years and hold hands in their sleep across the gap between the beds. Room 11, Mr. Osei, who does not sleep either and who has read four hundred pages of the same Wilbur Smith since January and who lifts a hand to me without looking up.

This is the part of the job nobody writes about. It's not dramatic. It's eleven people breathing in eleven rooms and one woman walking between them making sure they keep doing it.

I love it. I've never once said that out loud to anyone.

Room 12 rings at eleven forty. Mrs. Ferrante is awake and sitting up, hands folded on the blanket like she's waiting for a train.

"You're early," she says.

"I'm right on time, love."

"No." She looks at me with the specific clarity she gets sometimes, the kind that makes the word *dementia* feel like a lazy label somebody stuck on a person to stop having to listen to her. "You're early. She hasn't gone yet."

I check her chart. I check her water. I do the things my hands know how to do while the rest of me stands very still.

"Who hasn't gone yet, Mrs. Ferrante?"

But the clarity has already drained out of her face, and she's asking me whether her husband has taken the car, and her husband has been dead since 2009, and I tell her he's parked out front and she says *good, good,* and settles back into the pillow.

I write it in the log. *Patient briefly disoriented, settled without medication, 23:52.*

What I don't write in the log is that Marguerite Ferrante has said *you're early* to me every night for eleven months, and that in eleven months I have never once asked her early for what.

That's not true. I asked her once, in April. She said something I didn't catch and I let it go because there was a fall in room 5 and by the time I came back she was asleep.

I have thought about that unheard sentence perhaps forty times since.

The middle of a night shift has a shape. Between one and three you do the paperwork nobody does in daylight: the audits, the fridge temperatures, the controlled drugs count that takes two signatures and eleven minutes and which Angela and I have done together so many times we no longer speak during it.

Tonight Angela is on the other wing, so I do the count with Priya, who is on her third week of nights and still thinks they're interesting.

"Does it get boring?" she asks, while I'm reading numbers off a blister pack.

"Yes."

"Everyone says the nights are peaceful."

"Everyone who says that works days."

She laughs. She has a good laugh, unguarded, the laugh of someone who has not yet had a phone call at ten past one in the morning.

"Can I ask you something?" she says. "Why nights? You could do days. You've got the seniority, Denise would have you on days tomorrow."

I count out four ampoules and write the number in the column.

"I like knowing where everybody is," I say.

It's the truest answer I've given anybody in fourteen months and she takes it for a joke, and laughs again, and I let her.

At three in the morning the building goes quiet the way it does, and I sit at the desk with the tea I make and never drink, and I take out my phone to look at nothing in particular.

I have one new voicemail.

The number is Nina's.

I want to be precise here, because precision is the only thing I have left that still works. I don't mean a number that looks like Nina's. I don't mean a number similar to Nina's. I mean the number I called four hundred times in the six weeks after the accident just to hear the recording of her voice saying *leave a message, or don't, I'll probably see you anyway.*

The voicemail is timestamped 2:14 this morning.

Nina has been dead for fourteen months.

I don't listen to it. I want that on the record too, whatever record this turns out to be. I sit in a corridor lit like an aquarium at three in the morning and I look at a notification on a screen and I do not press play, because some part of me that is still doing its job knows that the moment I press play I will stop being a person who can finish this shift.

Room 12 rings again. I go. Mrs. Ferrante wants the curtain open so she can see the car.

I open the curtain. Outside there's the car park, four cars, a sodium light doing its orange work on the wet tarmac.

"Good," she says. "Good."

When I get back to the desk my phone is face down where I left it, and the key is in my pocket again.

I take it out and set it on the desk in front of me and I look at it for a long time. Brass. Number 47. Cold.

I did not put it there. I put it on the shelf by the kettle, next to the box of teabags with the lid that doesn't close, and I have not been back into the staff room since.

The thing about not sleeping, the thing nobody tells you, because the people who tell you things about sleep are people who sleep, is that it doesn't feel like

exhaustion. Not after the first months. It feels like standing slightly to the left of your own body. Everything still works. You still take blood pressure and chart medications and talk to a frightened old woman about a car that isn't there. You just do it from an inch outside yourself, watching your hands be competent.

From an inch outside myself, I watch my hands put the key back in my pocket.

At six I hand over to Priya, who is twenty-six and sleeps eight hours a night and has the unbothered face of someone the universe has not yet started messing with.

"Anything?" she says.

"Twelve was up twice. Nothing else."

"You look like hell, Elena."

"Thank you, I've been working on it."

She laughs. I laugh. My laugh sounds fine. I have practiced it in the way you practice a signature.

In the car park the sodium light has gone off and the sky is doing the grey thing it does in February, and I sit in my car with my hands on the wheel and I do not start the engine.

I take out my phone.

One new voicemail, 2:14 a.m.

I press play.

Fourteen Months of Static

The voicemail is eleven seconds long.

The first four are nothing. Not silence: the particular textured nothing of a call placed somewhere with air moving. A room with a window open. A car with the engine off.

At second five there's a sound that might be a breath.

At second seven, a voice says something that is either two syllables or three, and I have listened to it ninety times since and I still cannot tell you which.

Then it ends.

I sit in the car park at Ridgemont with my phone against my ear and the heating off and my breath fogging the windscreen, and I play it again. And again. And on the fourth listen I start doing the thing I know better than to do, which is filling in the gap with a word.

Elena.

It could be *Elena.* It could be a car door. It could be a woman two streets away calling a dog.

I drive home doing thirty in a forty because my hands have started shaking and I am aware, in the detached way I'm aware of most things now, that this is a physiological response to shock and that it will pass in about twenty minutes.

The flat is exactly as I left it. That sounds like a stupid thing to note. It isn't. I've started noticing it every time (the specific arrangement of things, the mug on the drainer, the angle of the chair) because noticing it means I can compare it against the next time, and comparison is the only way I have left of knowing whether the world is behaving.

Everything is where it should be. Good.

I sit down at the kitchen table without taking my coat off and I put the key next to the phone and I look at the pair of them like they might resolve into something if I stare hard enough.

Here is what I know about my sister.

Nina was twenty-nine. She taught year fours and had the specific patience that requires and none of the patience required for anything else. She could not queue. She could not wait for a kettle. She once left a restaurant because the starters took eighteen minutes, and I know it was eighteen because she timed it and told the waiter.

On the fourteenth of December she drove home from a party on the Kesselwood road at twenty past midnight and went through the barrier on the bend where the road drops toward the river. There was no other vehicle. The report used the phrase **loss of control consistent with excess speed.** Her blood alcohol was over the limit. Not spectacularly. Over.

The coroner said what coroners say. Detective Okonjo, who I met twice, who has a way of listening that makes you keep talking past the point where you meant to stop, said what she was allowed to say, which was that there was nothing further to investigate, said kindly, said twice.

I was at home that night. That's the sentence I've said perhaps two hundred times, to police, to my mother, to the woman from the counselling service, to Nina's friends who wanted to know if she'd seemed all right. **I was at home that night.** It has the smoothness of a sentence that has been handled a lot.

There's a thing I do that I have never told the counselling woman about, and it is this: I keep a list.

It's in the notes app on my phone, and it's called **Groceries**, which is a level of cowardice I'm aware of. It has forty-one items on it. They are all the things about that night that don't sit right.

Item one: **she said see you at Mum's, and we weren't going to Mum's until the 23rd.**

Item four: **nobody at the party remembers her leaving.**

Item eleven: **the taxi.**

Item nineteen: **why did she park at the ring road that morning.**

Item thirty-three: **her keys.**

Nina's house keys were never found. Not in the car, not in the water, not on the verge, not in the bag they gave my mother in a plastic envelope with a form to sign.

Her phone was there. Her purse was there, with forty pounds in it and a receipt from a garage. Her keys, on the ring with the enamel puffin she bought in Reykjavik and would not shut up about, were not.

I asked about it twice. The first time a very young officer said things move about in an impact, which is true. The second time, six weeks later, a different officer said they'd have been logged if they'd been recovered, which is also true, and which is not an answer to the question I was asking.

Item forty-one is the newest and it says: *2:14.*

I take out my laptop and I search *voicemail delayed delivery fourteen months* and I read forum posts by people who are angry at telecom companies. It happens, apparently. Carrier faults. Messages that sit in a queue on a server for weeks. I find one case where a man received a voicemail six months late.

Six months is not fourteen. But six months proves the mechanism, and once you have the mechanism, the rest is just a bigger number.

That's what I tell myself, and it works for almost an hour, and then I think: the timestamp says 2:14 *this morning*. Not the fourteenth of December. This morning. Which means either the phone is recording the delivery time rather than the call time (plausible, likely, probably documented somewhere in a support page I could find if I looked) or the call was placed at 2:14 this morning.

At 2:14 this morning I was on the second floor of Ridgemont Care Home, checking a drip.

There's a thing that happens with grief and paperwork that nobody warns you about.

For about six weeks after a death, you are extremely busy. There are forms. There is a registrar's appointment and a certificate that costs eleven pounds a copy and you need nine copies. There are banks to ring, each of which has a bereavement department staffed by people who are unexpectedly, disarmingly kind, and each of which requires the same conversation from the beginning.

I did all of it. My mother could not, and there was nobody else, so I sat at this table with a folder and a list and I closed my sister's life down in six weeks flat.

I cancelled her gym. I cancelled a magazine subscription she'd had since university. I rang a dentist to cancel a check-up on the nineteenth of January and the receptionist said "and can I ask why she's cancelling?" and I said the words and she said "oh, love" and I had to sit on the floor.

And then it stops.

That's the part. Around week seven you close the last account and there is suddenly nothing to do, and the not-having-anything-to-do is where it comes for you.

I think a lot about the fact that the insomnia didn't start at the funeral. It started in the last week of January, the week the folder was finished.

I go to bed at eight in the morning with the blackout blind down and my body making the specific complaint bodies make when you ask them to sleep against the sun.

I do the routine. Blind down. Phone face down and across the room. Fan on for the noise. The counselling woman gave me a list and I still do the list, more out of superstition now than belief.

I lie there and my brain does its thing, which is to take the eleven seconds and run them like a strip of film that's been spliced into a loop. Breath. Two syllables. Or three.

Around ten I fall into the shallow part of sleep where you can still hear the traffic.

Around eleven I'm awake again, and I know without checking that I've had less than an hour, because I've become an instrument that measures this. Fourteen months of calibration.

The insomnia started the week after the funeral. That's not unusual, the doctor said, and gave me two weeks of zopiclone and a leaflet. The two weeks ended. The insomnia didn't. It settled in and made itself comfortable and eventually stopped feeling like a symptom and started feeling like a fact about me, the way my height is a fact about me.

Three hours a night, broken into pieces. Sometimes four. In November I had a run of five nights on maybe two hours each and at the end of it I was seeing the corner of my own vision move, little dark shapes that turned into nothing when I looked directly at them. I told nobody. I went to work. My hands were fine.

At noon I give up and get up and stand in the shower until the water goes cold.

And then, because I have been putting it off since six in the morning and I have run out of ways to not do it, I get the key out of my coat pocket and I look at the number stamped on the bow.

47.

Not a house. Houses don't have keys like this. Padlocks do. Lockers do. Storage units do.

There is a place on the Kesselwood road, about a mile before the bend, with a sign that says SECURE SELF STORAGE, 24HR ACCESS in letters big enough to read at fifty miles an hour. I have driven past it perhaps three hundred times. I have never once gone in.

I sit on the edge of the bath with a towel around me and the key in my hand and I think: I am not going to do this.

And I watch myself, from an inch outside, reach for my clothes.

The Last Dinner

I don't go to the storage place.

I get as far as the car. I get as far as putting the key in the ignition and sitting there with the engine running and the wipers going against a rain that has just started, and then I turn the engine off and go back inside, and I am not going to pretend to you that I know why.

Actually, no. That's the first lie, and we're only three days in, so let me correct it while I still can.

I know why. I didn't go because if unit 47 exists, and if the key opens it, then somebody rented a storage unit on the road where my sister died, and put the key in my coat, and I would have to find out who. And there is a version of that answer I am not ready to hold in my hands.

So I went inside and made toast I didn't eat, and I thought about the last dinner instead.

It was the eleventh of December. Three days before. She came to mine because her boiler had gone and she said my flat was the only place in the city guaranteed to be too hot, which was true and which she said like an insult and meant like a compliment.

She brought wine. She always brought wine, good wine, more than we'd drink, because she'd rather waste money than be the person who brought the second-cheapest bottle.

We had pasta. I remember the pasta because I remember being annoyed that I'd overcooked it, and Nina eating it anyway and saying it was perfect in the specific tone that meant it wasn't and she didn't care.

Here is the part I have gone over so many times the edges have worn smooth.

Around ten she got quiet. Nina getting quiet was an event, like weather. She sat with her glass in both hands and looked at the radiator and said, "Can I ask you something and you not do your face?"

"I don't have a face."

"You have several. You have a whole collection."

"Ask me."

And she said, and I want to be exact about this, she said, "If I told you I'd done something stupid, would you help me fix it, or would you tell me it was stupid first?"

And I said, "Both. In that order. Obviously."

And she laughed, and I laughed, and she said "yeah, that's what I thought," and she drank her wine, and we watched forty minutes of a cooking programme neither of us was interested in, and at half eleven she called a taxi and hugged me at the door and said *see you at Mum's* and went.

That's the whole thing. That's everything.

I told the police that. I told them she'd seemed a bit off, that she'd hinted at something, and they wrote it down with the exact amount of interest you'd expect, which was: some, politely.

Would you help me fix it, or would you tell me it was stupid first.

Fourteen months of turning that over and it still won't open.

Here is the thing about my sister that I have never managed to explain to anybody who didn't know her, and that I need you to understand or none of the rest of this will make sense.

Nina was five years younger and had been in charge of me since she was about nine.

That's not a figure of speech. When our father left (I was fourteen, she was nine) I did the sensible things: I got the bus timetables sorted, I learned to do a shepherd's pie, I filled in the forms. And Nina walked into the kitchen one evening about three weeks in, at nine years old, and said, "You're being weird. You've stopped being annoying and it's worse."

I have thought about that sentence for twenty years. Nine years old.

She was the only person alive who could tell me a true thing about myself and have me actually hear it. Everybody else, I'd be composing the rebuttal before they finished. With her, it just went in.

Which is exactly why, when she sat on my sofa on the eleventh of December with a glass in both hands and asked me a question in the careful way she asked it, I made a joke.

I've had fourteen months to work out why, and I think it's this: it was the first time in twenty years the direction of travel had reversed. She was asking me for something. And I didn't have any equipment for it, so I reached for the thing I did have, which was being funny at her.

Both. In that order. Obviously.

She laughed. She let me off.

I have never been let off anything so completely in my life.

The doorbell goes at four.

I'm not expecting anyone. I never am. My mother phones on Sundays and does not visit; there is a whole architecture of grief in my family built around not looking at each other while we talk.

The man on the step is about forty, dark coat, wet hair, and he's holding a parcel with the resigned expression of a person who has been holding it for a while.

"This came to mine," he says. "Number twelve. You're twenty-one. I think the postman has a system and I think the system is that he doesn't have one."

"Thank you."

"Adrian." He shifts the parcel to his left hand and offers me his right, which is a formal thing to do on a doorstep in the rain, and which he seems to realise halfway through and commit to anyway. "I moved into twelve in October. I've seen you on the stairs. You keep unsociable hours."

"I work nights."

"Ah." He nods like this explains a thing he'd been quietly filing. "Nurse?"

"Care home."

"That's a job."

"It is."

I take the parcel. It's from an online pharmacy: magnesium tablets, the third supplement I've tried since November, all of which have done nothing for anything.

He doesn't leave. He stands there in the rain and looks past me into the flat, not intrusively, just the ordinary curiosity of a neighbour, and he says, "I teach music. Piano, mostly, some guitar. If you ever hear scales at nine in the morning and want to kill someone, it's me. I'll take the criticism."

"I'm asleep at nine in the morning."

"Then we're perfectly designed to never bother each other." He smiles. It's a good smile, unhurried. "Elena, is it?"

I stop.

The rain does its thing on the path. Somewhere down the road a car alarm starts and gives up.

"How do you know my name?"

"It's on the parcel." He turns his hand over, the parcel that is now in my hands, my name printed on the label in the middle of the address, exactly where names go.

"Right," I say. "Sorry. I'm — it's been a long shift."

"You said you work nights. Isn't every shift a long one?"

"It's been a long fourteen months."

I don't know why I say it. I don't say things like that to people I've known for ninety seconds. I don't say things like that to people I've known for years. Ask my mother.

Adrian doesn't do the face. That's the thing I notice, and the thing I will keep noticing for the next six weeks: he doesn't do the sympathetic head-tilt, the *oh I'm sorry*, the whole small performance people run when you accidentally hand them something heavy.

He just says, "Yeah. Some of them are."

Then: "There's a place on Farrow Street that does coffee at hours that would suit you. Four in the afternoon is basically their breakfast service. If you ever want to be awake near another human being, I'm usually there Thursdays."

"I'll bear it in mind."

"That's a no said politely, and I respect it." He steps back off the step, hands in pockets. "Night, Elena."

"It's four in the afternoon."

"Not for you," he says, and goes.

I shut the door and stand in the hall with the parcel and my heart going like I've run somewhere.

Here's the thing I do not say to him, and would not have said to anyone.

The parcel is addressed to *E. Marsh, 21 Halloway Court.*

It does not say Elena.

Detective Okonjo Is Very Kind About It

Ruth Okonjo has an office that looks like someone described an office to her over the phone. Grey walls, a plant that is technically alive, a photograph turned at an angle that means it faces her and not the person in the visitor's chair.

She remembers me. That's the first thing that unsettles me. I'd prepared for having to explain who I was, had the sentence ready (*my sister was the Kesselwood road, December, you took my statement twice*), and she came out to the front desk and said "Elena" before I'd stood up.

"You look tired," she says now, in the chair opposite, which from anyone else would be an insult and from her is just an observation entered into a record.

"I've got a good excuse."

"Nights, still?"

"Still."

She nods. She lets a silence sit. I have learned since that this is her whole technique and that knowing it doesn't help you at all.

I put the key on the desk between us.

She looks at it without touching it. "Tell me."

So I tell her. The pocket. The shelf by the kettle. The pocket again. I hear myself say the second part out loud for the first time and I hear how it sounds, and I keep going anyway, because stopping would be worse.

Then I tell her about the voicemail.

She asks to hear it. I play it. She listens with her head slightly down, and she asks me to play it again, and the second time she closes her eyes.

Eleven seconds. Breath. Two syllables, or three.

"Have you had it looked at?" she says.

"Looked at how?"

"There are people who can clean up audio. Not miracles. But sometimes."

"I don't know any people who can clean up audio, Detective."

"No," she agrees. "Most people don't." She takes a card from the drawer without hurrying, writes a name on the back, slides it across. "He's a friend. He's retired and he's bored and he'll do it for free if you let him talk at you about equipment for forty minutes."

I look at the card. Then at her.

"You're taking this seriously."

"I'm taking *you* seriously," she says. "That's not the same and I'd rather you knew the difference now."

I think about that for a second. "Say the rest of it."

"The rest of it is that carrier-delayed voicemail is a real, documented, boring phenomenon, and if you gave me a hundred cases like this, ninety-nine would be that." She folds her hands. "And the key is a key. Somebody dropped it in your pocket at work, or it's been in the lining and worked its way through. There is a version of this where you're a tired woman who is looking for a door because doors can be opened, and grief can't."

"And the other version?"

"The other version is that somebody is doing something to you. Which is a crime, and which I would be interested in." She says it evenly, no weight on it either way. "So I'm not going to tell you it's nothing. But I'm not going to tell you it's something either, and if you came here hoping I'd reopen your sister's case, I want to say clearly that a key with a number on it doesn't get me there."

"I know what it doesn't get you."

"Good."

There's a photograph on her desk, angled away from me. I can see the back of the frame and about a centimetre of the edge of the picture, and I catch myself trying to work out from that centimetre whether it's children or a dog.

She notices me noticing.

"Two boys," she says. "Nineteen and twenty-two. The nineteen-year-old is currently informing me that university is a scam."

"Is it?"

"Increasingly." She almost smiles. "I turn it round because people talk more freely at a desk that isn't showing them somebody else's family. You'd be surprised how many people stop halfway through a sentence when they see a photograph of a child."

I file that away as the first honest piece of technique anybody in this building has ever shown me.

I sit with my hands around a plastic cup of the worst coffee in the county and I ask the question I came to ask, and I ask it badly.

"Was there anything in her file that didn't fit?"

Okonjo's expression doesn't change but something behind it does.

"Elena."

"That's not — I'm not asking you to reopen it. I'm asking whether there was anything that didn't fit."

"Every file has something that doesn't fit," she says. "That's what files are. A person's last day is not a tidy document." She turns her mug a quarter turn on the desk. "In your sister's file, the thing that didn't fit was the timing. She left your flat at eleven thirty. The collision was at twelve twenty."

"That's fifty minutes."

"The drive is nineteen."

The room does something. Not spins. I'm not going to give you spinning rooms, I'm a nurse, I know what actually happens to bodies. The room does the thing where you become extremely aware of the chair.

"Nobody told me that."

"It's in the file. Nobody hid it from you." She watches me. "It's also thirty-one minutes on a December night on a road with two pubs on it and a petrol station. There are eleven boring explanations and I chased four of them and none of them went anywhere interesting, and after that it stopped being a good use of anybody's time."

"She was drunk and she stopped somewhere and then she drove."

"That's the most likely one, yes."

"You could have told me."

"You didn't ask," Okonjo says, and it isn't cruel, it's just true, and it lands like something dropped from a height.

I sit with it.

"That can't be right," I say. "I asked hundreds of questions. I rang this building so often the woman on the front desk knew my voice."

"You did." She doesn't look away. "You asked whether the barrier had been maintained. You asked about the road surface. You asked twice about the drainage, and I got a man from the council to send me a survey, and I sent it to you, and you rang back with a question about the camber."

"Because those were the things that—"

"They were all questions about the *road*," she says. "Not one of them was a question about your sister. In fourteen months you have never once asked me what state she was in when she left that party, or who she spoke to, or where she went for thirty-one minutes."

The clock on her wall does its thing.

"I've watched a lot of families do this," she says, more gently. "Everybody has a question they don't ask. Usually it's *did she suffer*. That one I understand." She turns her mug. "Yours isn't that one. Yours is a whole half hour, and I've been waiting fourteen months for you to notice it's missing." "You told me she was fine when she left. You told me twice. You told me she hugged you at the door and said *see you at Mum's*, and then you told me you were at home all night, and I believed you, and I still do." A pause, the exact length of a held breath. "You never once asked me what happened in between."

I don't have an answer for that.

I have never had an answer for that.

In the car park I sit in the driver's seat and don't start the engine and think about thirty-one minutes, and about what a person does with thirty-one minutes on the Kesselwood road at midnight in December, and about the fact that a mile before the bend there is a building with a sign you can read at fifty miles an hour.

SECURE SELF STORAGE, 24HR ACCESS.

I drive there. I sit in the car park with the engine running for eleven minutes by the clock on the dashboard.

Then I drive home.

That night at work, Mrs. Ferrante is awake at two, sitting up, hands folded.

"You're early," she says.

And this time I say, "Early for what?"

And she says, perfectly clearly, in a voice that is her own and not the frightened borrowed one she uses for the day staff: "She's still in the car, love. You've got time. Go on."

What Mrs. Ferrante Knows

There is a protocol for this. There is a protocol for everything, which is the part of the job that keeps you upright when the rest of it doesn't.

A patient with dementia says something that appears to reference real events. You do not engage with the content. You do not confirm, you do not deny, you do not chase. You orient gently, *it's Tuesday, love, it's two in the morning, you're at Ridgemont*, and you check their obs, and you write it in the log without editorial.

I stand at the foot of Mrs. Ferrante's bed and I do none of it.

"What car?" I say.

She's looking at the window. The curtain is closed. She'd asked me to open it two nights ago and tonight she hasn't asked, and I find that I want her to.

"The blue one," she says.

Nina's car was a blue Corsa with a dent in the passenger door from a bollard she swore had moved.

"Mrs. Ferrante." My voice comes out level. Fourteen years of nights have given me a voice that stays level while the rest of me does whatever it likes. "Who's in the car?"

"You know who." Not unkind. A little impatient, the way you'd be with someone slow at a crossword. "You were standing right there."

"Where?"

"By the door."

"Which door, love?"

And the light goes out of it. I watch it happen. I've watched it happen a thousand times, in this room and forty others, and it never stops being like seeing a tide go out fast. Her hands start working at the blanket hem. Her mouth softens.

"Is Roberto back with the car?"

Roberto Ferrante, died 2009, buried in the cemetery on Anderby Hill, whose funeral is described in the family notes in her file because his death is the event her memory keeps returning to and rebuilding.

"He's parked out front," I say.

"Good," she says. "Good."

I stand there for a while after she's gone under. The room does its night sounds. The radiator. The mattress pump. Somewhere down the corridor a door on a slow closer.

Then I go to the office and pull her file.

I'm not supposed to do that for this reason. I'm supposed to pull a file for clinical reasons and this is not one, and I know exactly what I'm doing as I do it, and I do it anyway, and I want that written down.

Marguerite Ferrante, 82. Admitted March of last year. Before that: sheltered accommodation on Bellhouse Row, and before that, forty-one years at 8 Kesselwood Cottages.

Kesselwood.

I sit with the file open on my knee in a room that smells of hand gel and printer toner and I do the arithmetic that anyone would do.

Kesselwood Cottages is a row of six houses about four hundred metres before the bend. You pass them on the left. There's a hedge and a gate and then the road starts to fall away toward the river.

She lived there until March of last year. The accident was the December before that.

She was living four hundred metres from where my sister died, on the night my sister died.

There's more in the file, and I read all of it, sitting on a plastic chair in a room that smells of toner at twenty past three in the morning.

Her admission was expedited. That's unusual. The waiting list at Ridgemont runs eleven months and people die on it. Marguerite Ferrante went from referral to bed in nine days, and the reason is in a social work note dated the second of March last year:

Mrs F unable to remain at current address. Repeated night-time wandering, on two occasions found on the carriageway. Neighbour intervention. Risk assessed as high, immediate placement sought.

On two occasions found on the carriageway.

I read it three times.

An eighty-two-year-old woman with dementia, who lived four hundred metres from a bend where my sister died, was walking out onto that road at night, repeatedly, in the months afterward.

There's a second note, from a different hand, undated:

Family GP reports Mrs F has become preoccupied with a road traffic incident in the vicinity of her property (Dec, previous year). Discussed with daughter of neighbour, no family of her own. Reassurance given. Preoccupation likely fixation secondary to cognitive decline; content not reality-based.

Content not reality-based.

Somebody wrote that sentence about a woman who had stood at her gate in a dressing gown and heard it happen.

I put the file back. I finish my rounds. I chart everything I'm meant to chart and nothing I'm not.

Before Priya comes on I do the last round, which at Ridgemont is the one everybody says they like and nobody explains why.

Half five. The building starts to change. There's a specific grey that comes into the corridors about twenty minutes before the day staff arrive, and the machine that has been running for eight hours starts handing itself over.

Mr. Osei is asleep with the Wilbur Smith open on his chest, page two hundred and eleven, which is four pages further than yesterday.

The Kelly sisters, who are not sisters, have found each other across the gap again.

Mrs. Duffy has kicked the blanket off and I put it back, and she says something in her sleep that is not words, and settles.

In room 7 Mr. Aldridge is awake, sitting on the edge of the bed with his slippers on the wrong feet, waiting.

"It's not time yet, love."

"I know," he says. "I like to be ready."

I swap his slippers round. He watches me do it with the total absence of embarrassment of a man of eighty-eight who has decided that dignity is a thing other people can worry about.

"You look tired," he says.

"Everyone keeps telling me that."

"Well," says Mr. Aldridge, "we've got nothing else to do in here but look at you."

At six, Priya arrives with her hair wet and a coffee in each hand and gives me one without being asked, which is a small kindness I have no idea how to receive, and I take it and say thanks and drink it and it's too sweet.

"Elena." She's looking at me over the lid of her cup. "Can I say a thing?"

"You're going to."

"You've done four nights in a row."

"I've done four nights in a row for eleven years."

"Yeah, but you *used* to go home and sleep." She says it lightly. She's twenty-six and she says things lightly and it's not a technique, it's just how she is. "Now you go home and I don't know what you do, but you come back looking like you did it standing up."

I could tell her. There's a version of this morning where I sit down on the stairs by the fire door and tell Priya Chandran about a key and a voicemail and thirty-one minutes and an eighty-two-year-old woman who used to live four hundred metres from the bend, and Priya listens, and says *that's a lot, Elena*, and it becomes a thing two people know instead of a thing one person is carrying.

I say, "I'm fine. I'll sleep today."

She nods, and lets it go, and that's the mercy and the tragedy of colleagues: they let it go.

I don't sleep.

I get home at half six and pull the blind and lie in the dark and my brain does the thing.

You were standing right there.

By the door.

Here is what I know about that night, and I'm going to set it out plainly, because I think if I set it out plainly the shape of it will hold.

Nina left mine at eleven thirty in a taxi. I know because I heard the taxi. I know because I stood at the window and watched her get in. I remember the specific way she got into cars, half a duck, half a fall.

I then washed up two pasta bowls and two wine glasses.

I then watched, I think, the end of the cooking programme.

I then went to bed.

At ten past one my phone rang and it was my mother, and my mother was making a sound I had never heard a person make.

Between going to bed and my mother's phone call there is nothing. Not a gap. That's the wrong word, a gap implies edges. There's just the ordinary blankness of a night you slept through, the same blankness as every other night I'd slept through in thirty-four years, indistinguishable from all of them.

That's the whole problem with sleep. It doesn't leave a receipt.

At eleven in the morning I get up, because lying there has stopped being rest and started being work.

There's a text from a number I don't have saved.

Ruth gave me your number. She says you've got eleven seconds you want cleaning up. I'm free most days, I'm retired, that's a joke that stops being funny around the third time. Ken Boyd

I look at it for a long moment.

Then I type: *Are you free today?*

Eleven Seconds, Cleaned

Ken Boyd lives in a bungalow in Farrow with a garage that has been converted into something between a studio and a museum. There are reel-to-reel machines on shelves. There is a mixing desk with more faders than seems reasonable for a man who is retired. There is a cat asleep on a speaker cabinet that he introduces before he introduces himself.

"That's Duchess. She's deaf, which in this house is a career choice."

He's seventy-odd, small, moves like a man whose knees have opinions. He puts a mug of tea in my hands before I've taken my coat off.

"Ruth said your sister."

"Yes."

"I'm sorry." He says it once, plainly, and then doesn't say it again, and I could kiss him for it. "Right. Send it over."

I AirDrop him eleven seconds of nothing and he puts it on a screen and it becomes a shape: a long flat line with a bump at the front and a longer bump near the end.

"Okay," he says, and he's already somewhere else, the way people go when you hand them their own subject. "First thing. This isn't a recording of a room. This is a recording of a phone in a place, which is different, because the phone's got its own noise floor and its automatic gain is fighting you the whole time." He points at the flat part. "That's not silence, that's the gate. Your carrier compresses voicemail to hell. Anything quiet gets thrown away before it ever reaches you."

"So there could be more."

"There *was* more. There's no getting it back. What's left is what survived the compression." He clicks something. The waveform gets taller. "But what survived can be helped."

He works for forty minutes. He talks the entire time: about noise reduction, about a thing called spectral repair, about a job he did in 1994 for a coroner in Leeds that he clearly still thinks about. I drink the tea. Duchess relocates from the speaker to my lap without consulting me.

"You'll want to know about the Leeds one," he says, without turning round, which is how I learn that Ken Boyd has been building to this for half an hour.

"Go on."

"Girl of nineteen. Answerphone message, forty seconds, family said it was her, police said it wasn't." He drags something across the screen. "It was her. Took me a week. And when I told the mother, she asked me a question I've never got over, which was: *does that mean it's my fault I didn't pick up?*"

The garage hums. Somewhere out the back a boiler fires.

"What did you tell her?"

"I told her I do sound, not fault." He shrugs, one shoulder. "Which was a cowardly answer and I've had thirty years to think of a better one and I haven't." He glances at me sideways. "You'll ask me that question at some point. Not today. But you will, and I want you to know in advance that I'm going to give you the same cowardly answer, because it's the only true one I've got."

"I wasn't going to ask you anything."

"No," Ken agrees, pleasantly. "Nobody ever is."

"Right," he says at last. "Two things. Then a third thing, and you're going to want to sit down for the third thing, except you're already sitting down, so."

"Just tell me."

"One. The background." He plays a loop of the first four seconds, cleaned. Under the hiss there's something now: a low, regular pulse. Very faint. About one beat a second.

"What is that?"

"Indicator relay. Hazard lights, or an indicator left on." He shrugs. "Could be a car with the ignition off and the hazards going. Fits the noise floor — you're in a small enclosed space with soft surfaces."

A car. With its hazards on.

I put my hand on the cat because my hand needs to be on something.

"Two." He plays the section near the end. "Your two syllables. It's not two. It's three, and the middle one's mostly gone because it's a soft consonant and the gate ate it."

He plays it again. And again. And the fourth time my brain does the thing brains do, the click, and I hear it.

El-e-na.

"That's my name," I say.

"That's a three-syllable word with the stress on the second," Ken says carefully. "It's consistent with your name. I'd not swear to it in a courtroom and neither should you."

"It's her voice."

"It's *a* voice. Eleven seconds through a bad codec." He turns in his chair to look at me properly, and his face has gone gentle in a way I didn't expect from a man with this many faders. "Elena. I do this a lot. Or I did. And the thing that happens is people bring me eleven seconds and what they want is for me to give them back a person. I can't do that. I can tell you it's a female voice in the mid range and it's not obviously synthetic. That's the honest end of it."

"You said there was a third thing."

"Yeah." He hesitates, which he hasn't done once in forty minutes. "The file's got metadata. Most people never look. Voicemail files carry a chunk that tells you when the recording was made — not when it was delivered to your phone, when the network *made* it."

He turns the screen.

There's a field. There's a date in the field.

14 December, 00:31.

I look at it. The room does the chair thing again.

Fourteenth of December. Thirty-one minutes past midnight.

Eleven minutes before the collision.

"So it's not delayed," I say. My voice comes out from an inch to the left. "It's — she called me. That night. From the car."

"The recording was made that night, yes."

"Then why did it arrive yesterday?"

And Ken Boyd, who has been generous and clear and kind for the last hour, looks at me with something I don't like at all, and says:

"That's the bit I can't explain. Because files don't sit in a queue for fourteen months, love. They sit for a week. Maybe a month, if somebody's system is on fire." He scratches Duchess behind the ear without looking at her. "For this to reach you yesterday, it wasn't in a queue. It was *somewhere*. And then somebody moved it."

Before I leave, Ken says: "One more thing and then I'll let you go."

He's turned off the monitor. That's deliberate; I notice it and I appreciate it.

"The gate on that recording. The compression." He rubs the back of his neck. "I said anything quiet gets thrown away. That's true. But there's a bit at the very end, after your three syllables, about a second and a half, where the noise floor changes."

"Changes how?"

"It gets *quieter*." He shrugs, uncomfortable. "Which happens when a phone is moved away from a source of noise. Or when a car door shuts."

"So she got out of the car."

"Or somebody else got in," says Ken Boyd. "Or she put the phone down. Or she moved her arm. That's the honest end of it and I'd like you to hold on to the honest end, because you've got the look of somebody who's about to build a house on eleven seconds."

I drive home the long way. I don't decide to; I just find myself on the ring road, going past the exit I want, and then the next one.

She called me at 00:31.

I did not answer.

I was asleep, or I was not asleep, and either way I did not answer, and eleven minutes later my sister went through a barrier on the Kesselwood road.

And there is a woman in room 12 who lived four hundred metres from that barrier, who looks at me with her whole self and says *you were standing right there.*

I pull into the car park at Secure Self Storage at ten past four in the afternoon.

This time I get out of the car.

Unit 47 Is Not There

The office at Secure Self Storage smells of new carpet and old coffee. There's a man behind the desk in a branded fleece, mid-twenties, reading something on his phone with the specific stillness of someone who has been told not to.

"Help you?"

"I've got a unit here. I need to check the details."

"Name?"

"Elena Marsh."

He types. He frowns at the screen in the way people frown at screens, which means nothing and which I read everything into.

"Spell the surname?"

"M-A-R-S-H."

More typing. The frown deepens into something with actual content in it.

"Sorry — nothing under Marsh. You sure it's this branch? There's a Cranleigh site as well, that's the other side of—"

"Unit 47," I say. "Can you look it up by unit?"

"I can see who's got it, I can't tell you who's got it. Data protection." He says it apologetically, and then, because he is twenty-five and bored and I am a tired woman in a coat who has clearly not slept, he glances at the screen and his face changes. "Hang on. There isn't a 47."

"What?"

"We go 1 to 40 in the main block, then it's A1 to A24 in the annexe. There's no 47." He turns the monitor a few degrees so I can see the grid, which is exactly what data protection would suggest he not do. "See? Forty and then it stops."

I look at the grid on the screen. Forty units. Then the annexe with its letters.

"Do you have a padlock system? Brass keys, number stamped on the—"

"No, it's all electronic. Fob on the door of the block, then customers bring their own padlock." He shrugs. "Some people use brass ones, but the number would be the manufacturer's, not ours. Could be anything. Could be a locker at a gym."

I stand in the office with the key in my fist and the new-carpet smell in my throat.

"You all right?" he says.

"When did this site open?"

"About four years back."

"Was there anything here before?"

"Yeah, it was a garden centre. Closed down." He's warming to it now, glad of something to do. "My mum used to come here for bedding plants. There's still a bit of the greenhouse round the back they never took down."

I thank him. I go outside.

I stand in the middle of the car park in the February dark that starts at four in this country, and I look up the road, west, toward the bend I cannot see from here because there's a rise in the way.

Then I walk round the back.

The greenhouse is there, or a third of it: a rusted frame with most of the glass gone, standing in a rectangle of gravel that the storage company clearly ran out of budget before dealing with. There's a chain-link fence with a gap in it. There's a shopping trolley on its side, which is the international symbol for a place nobody comes to.

There's nothing here. Of course there's nothing here. What did I think I would find, a door with 47 on it and my sister's handwriting on a label?

I put my hands over my face and stand in the gravel and I don't cry, because I haven't managed that since the second week, but I do the thing that happens instead, which is a kind of dry shaking that goes on for a minute and then stops.

When I take my hands down I look at the key again, properly, in the light of my phone torch.

Brass. Cut square. Stamped **47** on the bow.

And on the other side of the bow, so faint I've been running my thumb over it for four days without registering it, there are three more characters, worn nearly flat.

ELP

Not a word. Part of one.

I photograph it. I zoom in until it's mush. I try to think of what ELP could end or begin.

HELP. YELP. WHELP.

Or it isn't part of a word at all. Or it's a maker's mark. Or it's nothing, the way most things are nothing.

I stand in the gravel behind a storage facility that used to be a garden centre and I think about the fact that I have driven past this place three hundred times.

Three hundred times, minimum. Every trip to my mother's goes this way. Every trip to the retail park. The Kesselwood road is not a road I avoid; it's the road, the one everybody in this town uses, and in fourteen months I have gone past that bend perhaps a hundred and fifty times and I have never once stopped.

I've always been slightly proud of that. In a grim way. *I don't do the shrine thing. I don't put flowers on a verge. I drive past at forty like a person with a life.*

Standing in the gravel it occurs to me for the first time that not stopping is not the same as being all right about it, and that a woman who arranges never to slow down on a particular stretch of B road has arranged something.

Adrian is on the stairs when I get back to the flats, sitting on the third step from the top with a guitar case beside him and his phone in his hand, and he stands up too fast when he sees me, which is the first ungraceful thing I've seen him do.

"I was about to give up," he says.

"On what?"

"On waiting. Which sounds a lot worse out loud than it did in my head." He picks up the case. "It's Thursday."

"It's what?"

"Thursday. Farrow Street. Coffee at an hour that suits a person who works nights." He watches my face. "You said you'd bear it in mind. I'm aware that's not a yes. I've been sitting here for eleven minutes calling it a maybe."

Under any other circumstance I would say no. I have said no to every invitation issued to me since December of last year: my mother's, Priya's, the counselling group's, twice.

I hear myself say: "Not coffee."

"Okay."

"There's a pub on Farrow Street. The Ring. It's terrible."

"I've been," he says. "It's genuinely terrible. Yes."

The Ring has a carpet that was chosen in about 1988 by somebody who has since apologised. There are four people in it and two of them are the same man in a mirror. The barmaid puts my drink down and says "you all right?" in the way that is not a question.

I have not been in a pub in fourteen months. I notice this at the exact moment I sit down, the way you notice a tooth.

We go to The Ring, which is terrible, and I drink half a pint of something bad, and he asks me nothing about myself for forty minutes, which I realise afterward was a decision and not an accident.

He tells me about his students. He does an impression of an eleven-year-old boy playing Für Elise with a facial expression like a hostage. He tells me he moved here from Bristol in October after a divorce that he describes as "amicable in the way a controlled demolition is amicable."

And then, somewhere in the second half of my terrible drink, with no lead-up at all, he says:

"Can I ask about your sister?"

The pub does not go quiet, because pubs don't, but I go quiet.

"I never told you I had a sister," I say.

The Corridor I Was Never In

He doesn't flinch. That's what I keep coming back to afterward. He doesn't flinch, doesn't scramble, doesn't do the thing a caught person does.

He says: "No. You told me it had been a long fourteen months, and you said it like a date rather than a feeling, and then last week you were in the car park at half four in the morning not driving anywhere." He turns his glass a quarter turn. "And there's a photograph on your hall table you can see from the door. Two of you. She's got your face and about eleven years fewer of it."

"You looked into my flat."

"You opened the door and handed me a parcel. I was standing at the threshold looking straight down a hallway." He says it evenly. "If it's a crime I'll take the sentence, but I'd like it recorded that most people would call it having eyes."

I sit there with my hands flat on the sticky table.

The trouble is it's all true. There is a photograph on the hall table. It is visible from the door. And I did say fourteen months like a date.

"Ask, then," I say.

"How did she die?"

Nobody asks that. Everybody asks *what happened* or *when did you lose her*, which are the same question dressed for church.

"Car. December before last. She'd been drinking, she came off the road on the Kesselwood bend."

"Was she on her own?"

"Yes."

"Were you close?"

"Yes."

"Then I'm sorry," he says, "and I'll stop, because I can see the exact point where you'd rather I did."

And he does stop. He goes back to the eleven-year-old and Für Elise. And I let him, and I laugh in the right place, and underneath it something in me is standing very still with its head cocked.

Because here's the thing I don't say.

The photograph on the hall table is not two of us. It's Nina on her own, at a wedding, holding a glass and mid-laugh.

There is no photograph of the two of us anywhere in that flat. There hasn't been since January of last year, when I put them all in a box in the wardrobe because I couldn't walk past them.

He got it right that I have a sister. He got the eleven years right, because she was five years younger, but she looked it, and people always said it.

And he got the photograph wrong in the specific way a person gets a thing wrong when they are describing something they were told about rather than something they saw.

Sunday night. Back on shift.

I'm doing the two a.m. drugs round when Bernie from security puts his head round the office door.

"El. Got a minute? It's probably nothing."

Bernie is sixty-one and has worked here longer than the building has had its current name, and when Bernie says *it's probably nothing* it is always, in my experience, nothing, and I have never once had my pulse do what it does now.

The security office is a cupboard with four monitors and a kettle. He sits down and pulls up the recording software with two fingers, hunting for keys.

"So we had the audit," he says. "Insurance. They want thirty days retained and a spot check, and I'm doing the spot check, and I've got a thing that doesn't make sense and I'd rather ask you than write it up."

"Ask me what?"

He finds it. Turns the screen.

It's the second-floor corridor. Timestamp bottom right: **Thursday 14 February, 02:47.**

The corridor is empty. Long, lit low, the fire door at the end with its green man. And then I walk into frame.

I come from the stairwell. I'm in my uniform. I stop about six feet in, and I stand there, facing the wall. Not the wall, the door, room 24. And I stand there for a long time. Bernie scrubs the timeline forward and I keep standing there. The counter runs on. Two minutes. Four.

At six minutes and change I turn around and walk back to the stairwell, and the corridor is empty again.

"Now," says Bernie. "Second floor's shut. Has been since November, they're doing the flooring, there's nobody up there and nothing to do up there. And you're not on the sheet for a second-floor check because there isn't one." He looks at me, mild, entirely without suspicion, because Bernie has known me eleven years. "So what were you doing, love? Because if there's a reason I'll put the reason in the log and we're done."

I look at the woman on the screen.

She has my hair, tied the way I tie it. She has my uniform, my shoes, the specific way I stand with my weight on the left because of the thing with my knee.

I do not remember being in that corridor.

I do not remember waking up on the fourteenth of February with any sense that the night had been unusual. I worked. I handed over to Priya. I went home. I have the handover notes in my own handwriting.

"Can you play it again?" I say.

He plays it again.

I make myself watch it properly this time, the way I'd watch a patient's gait: clinically, looking for the tell.

The woman comes out of the stairwell at a normal walking pace. Her arms swing. She is not shuffling and she is not gliding and she does not have her hands out in front of her like the thing people do in films.

At the door she stops. Square on. Both feet.

And then, at about the ninety-second mark, she does something that puts a cold line straight down my spine.

She reaches up with her right hand and tucks a piece of hair behind her ear.

It's nothing. It's a thing I do forty times a day. It's a thing I have done since I was eleven years old and my mother told me to stop.

It is also, categorically, not a thing a body does on autopilot in the middle of a non-REM parasomnia, because it is not walking or standing or opening a door. It's a small vain fussy gesture made by a person who is aware of herself in a room.

"Bernie," I say. "Can you go back thirty seconds and let it run without me talking?"

He does.

I watch the woman on the screen tuck her hair behind her ear at 02:48:31 on the fourteenth of February, on a floor that has been closed since November, outside a room that has been stripped to the boards.

And then, and this is the part I do not tell Bernie, or Okonjo, or anybody, for another five weeks, she turns her head very slightly toward the camera.

Not to it. Past it. The way you glance at something you already know is there.

I watch myself walk out of the stairwell and stop in front of a door on a floor that has been closed for four months, and stand there without moving for six minutes and eleven seconds, and then walk away.

"El?"

"What's in room 24?"

"Nothing. They're all stripped. Boards up." Bernie shrugs. "It's a shell."

"Whose room was it?"

"Christ, I'd have to look. Why?"

"Just look. Please."

He grumbles his way into another system, the resident database, and types the way he types.

Then he stops.

"Well, that's a coincidence," he says. "That was Mrs. Ferrante's, before we moved her down to twelve."

The Locker Room

I tell Bernie I was checking a smell.

That's what I say. There was a smell on the stairwell, I went up to see if something had died in the void, I stood there working out where it was coming from, I decided it was nothing. It is a good lie because it is boring, and boring lies are the ones that get written into logs and never thought about again.

He writes it in the log. We're done.

I go back to the desk and I sit down and I put both hands flat on it and I breathe the way you're supposed to, four in, six out, the thing on the leaflet.

Six minutes and eleven seconds.

There's a word for this. I know the word, because I did a module on it and because I have looked it up at four in the morning more than once in the last year, sitting up in bed with the phone brightness right down.

Parasomnia. Non-REM. Sleepwalking, if you want the word people use, though the clinical version is broader and stranger than the cartoon of a person with their arms out. People drive. People cook. People have conversations that make grammatical sense and remember none of it.

And the biggest risk factor, the one at the top of every list, above alcohol, above medication, above stress, is chronic sleep deprivation.

I have not slept more than four hours in a night since December of last year.

Here's what stops me. In every account I've read, the sleepwalker is *asleep*. They have the flat, unfocused look of it. They move badly. Doors confuse them.

The woman on that monitor walked out of a stairwell at a normal pace, stopped at a specific door, stood at a normal posture, and left. She did not sway. She did not fumble. She walked like a woman who knew where she was going.

I go home at seven and I do not sleep, and at eleven I drive to my mother's.

I have not been to my mother's on a weekday in two years. She opens the door in her cardigan with a duster in her hand and says "is something wrong?" which is what she says now instead of hello.

"No. I was passing."

"You were not passing. Nobody passes Bellhouse." But she stands back and lets me in.

Nina's room is still Nina's room. Not a shrine (my mother is far too practical for a shrine) but the bed is made with the same duvet cover and there are three boxes stacked by the wardrobe with things in them that neither of us has been able to take to the charity shop.

"You can look," my mother says from the doorway. "You don't have to ask me."

I sit on the floor and go through a box.

Her school lanyard. A birthday card from a child in her class with a drawing of what is either a horse or a dog. Two paperbacks with the spines broken. A phone charger. A pair of sunglasses with one arm gone.

And underneath: a photograph in a frame, face down.

It's the two of us at Whitby in 2003. I'm nineteen and doing a face; she's fourteen and doing a better one.

"She had that on her windowsill at the flat," my mother says. "The police brought it back with the other bits."

"Why's it face down?"

My mother is quiet for a second.

"Because I couldn't decide where to put it," she says, "and face down felt like less of a decision."

I ask to see Mrs. Ferrante's admission notes properly. This time I do it the right way. I ask the manager, and I give a reason that is true enough to survive contact.

"She's been vocalising about her old address at night. I want to know what's in there that we might be able to use to settle her."

Denise says fine, and I sit in the office at half three with a lukewarm tea and the whole file.

Marguerite Ferrante. Referred from Bellhouse Row sheltered accommodation. Prior residence 8 Kesselwood Cottages, 41 years. Widow. No children.

Then, further down, in the section for personal effects logged at admission, in the biro handwriting of whoever was on that day:

1 suitcase, clothing. 1 photo album. 1 jewellery box (costume). 1 key, brass, unlabelled. Resident distressed when removal attempted, permitted to retain.

I read it four times.

I get up. I walk down the corridor. It's twenty to four in the morning and Ridgemont is doing the deep quiet, and I stand outside room 12 with my hand not quite on the door.

Then I go in.

She's awake. She is nearly always awake at this hour; it's why we understand each other.

"Mrs. Ferrante."

"You're early."

"I know." I sit down in the chair by the bed, which I have never done in eleven months of nights, because sitting down changes what a nurse is. "Can I ask you about your key?"

Her hands stop moving on the blanket.

"They took it," she says.

"Who did?"

"The woman with the clipboard." Her voice has gone thin and hard, the tone of a specific real grievance surviving in a mind that has lost so much else. "I told her. I said it isn't mine to give, I'm keeping it for her."

"For who?"

"For the girl in the car."

The radiator ticks. Down the hall, the door on the slow closer.

"Mrs. Ferrante, when you say the girl in the car—"

"She came to the door," she says. "It was very cold. She wanted to use the telephone and I said the line's been off since Roberto, love, but come in out of it, and she said no, she said she just needed a minute, and she sat on my wall." Her eyes are wet and completely present. "She was upset. She'd had a drink, I could smell it, I'm not stupid. I said don't you drive, you sit there. And she sat there. And then a car came the other way and she got up and went and I heard it."

I cannot speak.

"I heard it," she says again. "You don't forget that. It's not like on the television."

"What did you hear?"

"The bang. And then nothing at all, which is worse." She wipes her face with the flat of her hand, roughly, like a child. "I couldn't get down there. I've got my hip. I telephoned nobody because the line's been off since Roberto. I stood at the gate in my dressing gown and there was a torch down there, moving about."

"A torch."

"Somebody was down there before the ambulance," she says. "Somebody was down there for a while."

I sit with her until she goes under, which takes a long time, and while I sit there I do something I have not done in fourteen months, which is to think about it as a nurse.

Not as a sister. As the person who would be called if it happened in front of me.

A vehicle leaves the road at speed and enters water. The occupant is unrestrained or restrained. The mechanism of injury is deceleration: the body stops when the car stops, and the organs inside the body stop a fraction of a second later, and that fraction is what kills people.

There is a version of that where a person is alive for twenty minutes and drowns.

There is a version where a person is not alive at the moment the noise stops.

I have known both versions existed since the day it happened, and I have made myself not look at which one applied, and I have told myself that was because it didn't matter, and sitting in a chair beside an old woman at four in the morning I understand with complete clarity that it was because of the torch.

Somebody was down there before the ambulance.

If the first version is the true one, then somebody stood at that barrier while my sister was alive in the water and did not go down.

I get through the rest of the shift. I don't know how; the hands do it.

At six I hand over. At quarter past I'm in the car park and my phone rings and it's Ruth Okonjo, at twenty past six in the morning, which is not a time a detective calls you for a good reason.

"Elena. Are you at work?"

"Just finished."

"Can you come in. Not now — sleep first, I mean it, sleep first. This afternoon."

"What is it?"

There's a pause on the line, the sort of pause that has a decision in it.

"Ken sent me the file," she says. "The metadata. And I've done something I probably shouldn't have, which is put your sister's number through the system again." Another pause. "Elena, that voicemail wasn't stored by the carrier for fourteen months. It was retrieved."

"Retrieved from where?"

"From her account. Somebody logged into your sister's voicemail with the PIN, eleven days ago, and forwarded a saved message to your number." I can hear her breathing. "Which means somebody has had access to Nina's phone account this entire time. And I need to ask you a question, and I need you to think before you answer it."

"Ask me."

"Do you know your sister's voicemail PIN?"

I open my mouth to say no.

And what comes out, in a voice I recognise as mine and do not recognise as mine, is: "It's 1412. It's the date. She used it for everything."

What I Knew Without Knowing

Okonjo lets the sentence sit there on the line for a long moment.

"Right," she says. "Come in at two."

I do sleep, actually. That's the strange part. I get home at seven and lie down and go under like something cut, and I dream about the greenhouse behind the storage place, the rusted frame with no glass, and Nina is standing in it in her coat, and she's annoyed with me, and she says *you're not even looking in the right place, El,* and I wake at half twelve with my heart going and my mouth dry and the specific clarity you sometimes get after five hours, where everything is a bit too loud.

The clarity lasts about ninety seconds. Long enough to think one clean thought, which is:

I knew the PIN without having to remember it.

Not *I remembered it.* It came out of my mouth ahead of me, the way your own front door code does, the way a thing you have typed does: the fingers know before the head.

I have never in my life logged into my sister's voicemail.

Okonjo's office. The plant. The angled photograph.

"Before anything else," she says. "How much have you slept in the last week?"

"Why?"

"Because I'm going to tell you some things and I need to know what I'm talking to."

"About twenty hours."

"In a week."

"In a week."

She writes it down. She actually writes it down, and I want to be angry and I can't be, because it's the right thing to write down.

"Okay." She turns her chair. "Here's where we are, and I'm giving you all of it because I've decided that's better than the alternative, and I might be wrong.

"One. The voicemail was recorded at 00:31 on the fourteenth of December, from your sister's handset. That's real. Two. It was saved, not deleted. Three. Eleven days ago, someone accessed that mailbox remotely using the PIN and forwarded the saved message to your number. The access came from a mobile data connection. We can't tie a data connection like that to a person without a lot more paper than a closed accidental death gets me."

"So somebody's had her account for fourteen months."

"Somebody has had *access* to it, which is not quite the same and is much easier than you'd think. If nobody closes an account and the direct debit keeps running, the account keeps running." She taps the desk once. "Now the harder part. Her handset was recovered at the scene. It's been in a property store since. I've had it out. It hasn't been touched — it's still bagged, still logged, the last thing on it is the call to you at 00:31 that went to voicemail because your phone was off."

I sit forward. "My phone wasn't off."

"Your phone was off from 23:52 to 06:15."

"No." I hear my own voice go up and I bring it down. "No, my phone is never off. It's a work phone as much as anything, they ring me if there's—"

"Elena." She says it gently. "It's in the original file. It was in the original file fourteen months ago. Nobody made anything of it because nobody needed to: a woman goes to bed and turns her phone off, that's not a fact, that's a Tuesday."

I put my hands over my mouth.

"I don't turn my phone off," I say through them.

"I believe that you believe that."

"That's not—" I stop. Start again. "You said a torch."

"I said nothing about a torch."

"Mrs. Ferrante. My resident. She lived at 8 Kesselwood Cottages, four hundred metres from the bend, and she was there that night, and she says Nina sat on her wall for a while because she'd been drinking, and she says there was a torch down at the scene before the ambulance came."

Okonjo goes very still.

"Say that again," she says. "Slowly. And then I'm going to write it down, and then I'm going to ask you a question you're not going to like."

So I say it again, slowly, and she writes, and when she's finished writing she puts the pen down and looks at me.

"Here's the question. Are you aware that you've just told me your sister was alive and stationary four hundred metres from the crash site, during the thirty-one minutes I told you about last week — and that the only person who's given me that information is you?"

"Mrs. Ferrante gave it to me."

"Mrs. Ferrante is eighty-two and has a dementia diagnosis in her file. I'll go and see her, and I will listen to her properly, and I want you to hear me say that." She leans forward. "But if this ever became something, and a lawyer stood up and said *the witness with dementia was interviewed at four in the morning by the deceased's sister, alone, unrecorded* — do you see the shape of that?"

I see the shape of it.

"You think I'm feeding her."

"I think you're exhausted and you're looking for a door." Her voice doesn't change at all. "And I think somebody sent you that voicemail on purpose. Both of those can be true, and if they are, you are being handled, and the person handling you knows you haven't slept since your sister died."

I put the cup down.

"Can I say something you're not going to like?"

"You can say anything you like. I'm a police officer, it's mostly what happens to me."

"You keep telling me what you can't do." My voice comes out steadier than I expect. "You can't reopen it. You can't tie a data connection to a person. You can't use a witness with a diagnosis. You've told me four things you can't do and one thing you can, which was give me the number of a retired man with a cat."

Okonjo doesn't move.

"And I understand all of it," I say. "I work in a system too. I know what *no resource* looks like from the inside, I know it isn't personal, I know there's a woman on your desk right now who's alive and needs you more than my sister does. I'm not asking you to be a better police officer."

"Then what are you asking?"

"I'm asking whether *you* think something happened."

The plant on the windowsill has three dead leaves at the bottom that nobody has picked off.

"Yes," Ruth Okonjo says.

It is the first straight answer I have had from anybody in fourteen months and it goes through me like cold water.

"Since when?"

"Since about eleven minutes into the second time I interviewed you," she says. "And I want to be careful now, because there's a difference between a thing I think and a thing I know, and if I blur it for you I'll do more harm than good." She meets my eyes. "I have thought something was wrong with that file since February of last year. I have not been able to find it. Those are two separate facts and you'll want to weld them together, and I'd ask you not to."

On the way out she stops at the front desk and asks the civilian on duty for a form, and fills in three lines of it standing up, and I watch her do it without understanding what I'm watching.

"What's that?"

"Referral," she says, not looking up. "Victim support. You're entitled to it and you should have been offered it fourteen months ago and I've just checked and you weren't, because the file was closed as accidental and accidental deaths fall down a gap."

"I don't want—"

"I know you don't want it." She signs the bottom. "They'll ring you. You can tell them to get lost, and that's your business, but the offer will have been made and it'll be on the system that it was made, and if in eight months you change your mind you won't have to start from nothing."

She hands the form over the desk.

"That's not detective work," I say.

"No," Okonjo agrees. "That's the job, though."

She walks me out. In the corridor, near the doors, she stops.

"The key," she says. "Have you still got it?"

I take it out. She turns it over in her palm and looks at the worn characters on the reverse, the ones I photographed, the ELP.

"You've been reading these as letters," she says.

"They are letters."

"They're the end of a word stamped round a curve." She holds it up so the light rakes across it. "There's a mark before the E. It's not a letter, it's the bottom of a stroke. Could be a B. Could be an H." She hands it back. "Get it under a proper light. And Elena—"

"Yes?"

"Do you know a man called Adrian Cole?"

The corridor does the chair thing, except I'm standing.

"He's my neighbour," I say. "Why?"

"Because a man of that name paid your sister's phone bill in March of last year," she says. "Three months after she died."

The Notebook in My Own Hand

I don't go home.

I drive to Farrow and I sit outside Ken Boyd's bungalow for six minutes working out what I'm doing there, and then I knock, and he opens the door with reading glasses pushed up into his hair and Duchess winding round his ankles.

"I need a light," I say. "A proper one. Raking."

He doesn't ask. He says "come in," and he clears a space on the bench and he gets out a lamp on an articulated arm and lays the key on a piece of black card, and he moves the light down until it's almost flat against the metal.

The stamped characters come up out of the brass like something surfacing.

There's the mark Okonjo saw. It isn't part of a B or an H.

It's the tail of a **W**.

...WELP

"Turn it," Ken says quietly.

I turn it, and the rest of the stamp runs round the curve of the bow, worn but there once you know to look:

KESS · WELP

No. Not two words.

KESSELWELP.

"That's not a word either," Ken says.

"It's not finished." I'm turning it under the light, tilting. "There's more gone. Kesselw— something. Kesselwood."

"Kesselwood what?"

And then I get it, all at once, the way you get a crossword clue after twenty minutes of nothing.

Not Kesselwood.

****KESSELWOOD LP.****

"LP," I say. "Long Play. It's a record shop."

Ken looks at me over the glasses. "There's a Kesselwood Records on the industrial estate. Second-hand vinyl, been there since the eighties." He shrugs. "They do lockers. Storage for dealers who come to the fairs. Rows of them at the back, all brass padlocks with numbers on."

Kesselwood Records is a unit with a hand-painted sign and a doorbell that plays a bar of something I don't recognise. The man behind the counter has a grey ponytail and the resigned posture of someone who has explained his own pricing policy nine thousand times.

"Forty-seven," he says, when I show him the key. "Right at the back, past the seven-inches."

"You're not going to ask who I am?"

"You've got the key," he says. "That's the whole system. It's been the whole system since 1986 and it works because nobody wants to steal a load of Emerson Lake and Palmer."

The lockers are at the back, in a room that smells of dust and cardboard, three rows of grey metal doors with brass padlocks.

47 is at chest height.

The key turns easily. Whoever's been using this has been using it recently; there's no grind, no stick.

Inside, on the shelf, there is:

A shoebox.

And on top of the shoebox, a spiral-bound notebook, A5, the cheap kind you buy in a supermarket.

I take them both out and I sit down on the floor of a record shop storeroom with my back against the lockers, because my legs have made an executive decision.

Before I open anything I sit there and I do the thing I have been trained to do, which is to think about who else could have done this.

It's a short list and I make myself walk it.

My mother. Who has not driven at night since 2011 and who would have had to get a key cut, rent a locker in a record shop, and write sixty pages in my handwriting.

Adrian. Who I have known five weeks and who could not have written entries dated last January.

Somebody who knew Nina. Same problem: the handwriting.

That's the wall I keep hitting and have been hitting since the second page. It isn't a handwriting *like* mine. There is a loop on my lowercase g that my old ward sister used to take the mickey out of, an actual physical habit I have had since I was seven, and it is on every page.

So the list has one name on it, and I have known that since I sat down, and everything I have been doing for the last four minutes is a way of not turning round.

The shoebox first.

Nina's things. Not the important ones: not her jewellery, not her laptop, none of the objects the family divided in that awful week. Small things. A hair tie. A lipstick worn down to the metal. Three ticket stubs. A hotel keycard. A photograph of the two of us on a beach at Whitby in about 2003, curled at one corner.

And underneath: her house keys, on the ring with the enamel puffin she bought in Iceland.

Her house keys, which were never recovered, and which I reported missing to the police, and which are here in a locker in a record shop.

I put the box down carefully, the way you put down something that might go off.

Then I open the notebook.

The first page has a date at the top: **17 January**. That's five weeks after she died.

The handwriting is mine.

Not similar to mine. Mine. The specific way I make a lowercase g with the tail that doesn't close, the way I cross a t high, the leftward slant I've had since school and hated since school.

The entry says:

> *Went back tonight. Stood at the gate for a while. Nothing there now, they've cleared the glass. I keep thinking if I stand in the right place it'll come back and it doesn't. I don't know why I'm writing this down. I think because if I don't write it down I'll do it again and not know I've done it.*

I turn the page.

23 January.

> *Twice this week. Woke up in the car outside Mum's with the engine cold. Told her I'd come early. She was pleased.*

2 February.

> *M.F. moved rooms. She said the thing about the car again. I asked her to say it again and she wouldn't. I'm frightened of how much I want her to be right about something.*

M.F.

Page after page. Dates through the winter and spring and summer of last year, into the autumn, into January of this one. Some entries are three lines. Some run over. All of them are mine, and I have no memory, not a fragment, not a shadow, of writing a single word.

I sit on that floor and I read for a long time, and what gets me is not the content. It's the handwriting on page forty.

Because on page forty the writing changes. Not the hand, which is still mine, but the *pressure*. Up to page thirty-nine everything is written in the neat, small, slightly cramped way I write notes at work, the way you write when you might have to read it back to a coroner.

From page forty on, the pen goes through the paper in places.

> **11 September.** *Went again. Stood at the gate for an hour. A car stopped and a man got out and I went back to the car before he could get to me. I don't know who he was. I don't like that I don't know who he was.*

She knew. Some version of me, on that road, in September, saw Adrian Cole get out of a car and made a decision to leave before he reached her.

And then went home and got into bed and woke up and did not know it.

> **14 September.** *If someone stops me I'll have to explain and I can't explain. Stop going. STOP GOING.*

> **19 September.** *Went.*

I have to put the notebook down for a minute at that point. I sit in a storeroom that smells of dust and cardboard with my hand over my mouth.

Stop going. STOP GOING.

Went.

The most frightening thing in that notebook is not that a stranger wrote it. It's that she and I are exactly the same woman: she made a rule, in capitals, for her own good, and then broke it five days later, and wrote down that she'd broken it, in the same flat voice I use for everything.

I turn to the last written page.

The date is **eleven days ago**.

> *Found the account still open. PIN was the obvious one. There's a saved message from that night I never listened to. I'm going to send it to my phone so that she has to hear it. She won't do anything unless she has to.*

She.

I read it three times.

She won't do anything unless she has to.

I am sitting on the floor of a record shop reading a note that I wrote to myself, about myself, in the third person.

The First Lie I Tell Her

Okonjo asks me, on the Tuesday, whether I've made any progress with the key.
And I say no.

I want to be very clear about what happens in that moment, because it's the hinge of the whole thing and I have had a long time to look at it since.

I am sitting in her office. The notebook is in my bag, on the floor, between my feet. The shoebox is in the boot of my car with Nina's house keys in it, house keys I reported missing, which makes them, at minimum, an item of interest in a file, and which makes me, at minimum, a person who found them and said nothing.

She says: "Any joy with the key?"

And I hear myself say: "No. I've had it under a light. It's just a maker's mark."

There is no decision. That's what I want to put down. I do not weigh it up. There is no moment in which I consider telling her about a locker in a record shop and a notebook in my own handwriting and decide against it. The lie is simply what comes out, fully formed and calm, in the voice I use for handovers.

And the thing underneath it, the reason, which I can see now and could not see then, is this:

If I show her the notebook, then it stops being *possible* that I'm being handled by somebody, and starts being *certain* that for fourteen months I have been getting up in the night and doing things and coming back and putting the kettle on.

I am not ready for the certainty. So I lie, and I keep the possibility, and the possibility is the last comfortable room in the house.

"Okay," she says.

She writes nothing down.

That's what I take away from the meeting, in the end, and it takes me another eleven days to understand it: Ruth Okonjo asked me a direct question about a physical object in an active line of enquiry, received an answer, and wrote nothing down.

I read the notebook properly that night. Not at work. I've asked for two shifts off, which I have never done, and Denise agreed so fast that I understand I look worse than I think I do.

Sixty-one entries. Fourteen months.

Some of it is unbearable in an ordinary way. There's an entry from the week of what would have been Nina's thirtieth that just says **couldn't** four times.

There's one from March that is four pages long and is a letter to her, and I read half of it and stop, because it is addressed to **N** and it says **I keep doing the thing where I compose the text before I remember,** and I have done that thing perhaps two hundred times awake and had no idea I did it asleep as well.

There's one from an August night that says only: **Priya asked if I was all right and I said yes and she believed me, which is the most frightening thing that's happened to me this year.**

I remember that. I remember Priya asking. I remember saying yes.

I do not remember writing it down at four in the morning in a locker in a record shop, and both of those things are now true at once, and I have to sit with that.

But the pattern underneath the grief is the thing.

She, or I, or whoever writes in this notebook, goes back to the Kesselwood road. Repeatedly. Twenty-two of the sixty-one entries reference the bend, the gate, the cottages, the verge. There are measurements. There is, on one page, a sketch of the road with an X and an arrow and the note **no glass here, why*.*

There are entries about Mrs. Ferrante going back nine months, long before I would have said I'd ever exchanged more than pleasantries with her.

And there is one thread I do not understand at all, which starts in April:

> **A. was there. Not at it. After.**

Then in June:

> **A. still saying no. He's very good at it. He's not lying about the thing he thinks I'm asking about.**

Then in September:

> *A. has taken the flat downstairs. That's not a coincidence and I'm not going to pretend it is, but I don't think it's the kind of not-coincidence I've been assuming.*

A.

Adrian moved in in October. He told me October and the tenancy board in the hall says October.

The entry is dated the fourth of September.

Before I go downstairs I do something I have been avoiding for eleven days, which is to look properly at my own flat.

Not tidy it. Search it.

I start in the wardrobe because that is where I put things I can't look at, and the box of photographs is where I left it in January of last year, and under the box there is a carrier bag I do not recognise.

Inside the carrier bag: an Ordnance Survey map of the area, folded to the Kesselwood sheet, with a biro ring round the bend. A head torch, still in its packaging, bought from a shop on the retail park according to the sticker. A pair of walking boots, size six, mine, muddy, which I have never owned.

I sit on the bedroom floor with a pair of boots I bought and wore and cleaned nothing off.

The receipt is in the boot. Fourteenth of March last year, 04:51, twenty-four-hour supermarket on the ring road.

Ten to five in the morning. I would have been asleep. I was asleep. That's a Tuesday, I know it's a Tuesday because I did four nights that week and Wednesday was my first off, and I would have got home at seven on the Tuesday morning and gone to bed.

Except at ten to five I was in a supermarket on the ring road buying walking boots with my own bank card.

I check the statement on my phone, standing in the bedroom.

It's there. £34.99. I have looked at that statement eleven times in fourteen months and never once queried a thirty-five pound transaction, because who queries thirty-five pounds.

I go and knock on his door at nine in the morning, which is when he told me he does scales, and I can hear the scales through the door before I knock, so at least one thing in the world is what it claims to be.

He opens it. He's in a jumper with a hole in the elbow and he has a pencil behind his ear and he looks pleased to see me for about half a second before he reads my face.

"Right," he says. "Come in, or shall we do this here?"

"Here."

"Here it is."

"Did you know my sister?"

He doesn't flinch. He never flinches; I've catalogued it now, and it stopped reading as calm about four days ago and started reading as something else.

"Yes," he says.

I had a follow-up ready. I had six. All of them assumed a no.

"How."

"She was my student." He leans on the doorframe, not casually, like he needs it. "Guitar, badly, for about a year. She was the worst student I've ever had and the only one I ever looked forward to." Something moves across his face and he lets it. "She talked about you constantly. *My sister the nurse who doesn't sleep.* That was before — she meant it as a joke about your shifts."

"You paid her phone bill."

"Yes."

"Why?"

"Because in March her mother rang me — your mother rang me, she had my number from Nina's diary — and she said the account had gone to collections and she couldn't face dealing with it and could I, and I said yes." He rubs his face. "It was eleven pounds a month, Elena. I set up a direct debit and I forgot about it. I have been paying eleven pounds a month for fourteen months for a dead woman's phone because I didn't know how to say no to your mother on the phone in March."

"You moved into this building."

"I did."

"In October."

"Yes."

"On purpose."

And here, finally, he does something with his face.

"Yes," he says.

On Purpose

Before any of it, there is a thing I have to say, and I say it standing in his doorway.

"I've been sitting in my flat for two days deciding whether you did this to me."

Adrian doesn't move.

"Whether I did what?"

"The key. The voicemail. All of it." My voice is steady, which surprises me. "You knew my sister. You paid her phone bill, which means you had access to her account. You moved into this building in October. You knew my name before I told you and you gave me an explanation that was a lie — there's no photograph of the two of us in my hall, there hasn't been for a year."

He goes very pale. That's the first honest reaction I've had out of him and I watch it happen.

"Say something," I say.

"I'm trying to work out which bit to answer first."

"Answer the one you're most frightened of."

"They're all the same one," Adrian says. "Yes, I know how it looks. I've known how it looks since about November. There's a version of me standing here that you should absolutely be frightened of, and I've got no way of proving to you that I'm not him except by talking, and talking is exactly what he'd do."

We stand there.

"That's the most reassuring thing you could have said," I tell him.

"I know," he says. "That's the problem."

We do it in his kitchen after all, because you cannot have this conversation on a landing and both of us know it.

His flat is the mirror image of mine, which is disorienting: the same rooms in the wrong order, like a word said backwards. There's a piano where my sofa is. There are boxes he hasn't unpacked after five months.

He makes tea neither of us drinks. That's the second time this week somebody has done that for me.

"Start at the beginning," I say.

"The beginning is that she was my student and she died and I went to the funeral and stood at the back, which is where you stand when you're the guitar teacher." He wraps both hands round his mug. "And then about a month after, I was at the crematorium car park — I'd gone to put flowers, which I know is a thing people do and I still felt like an idiot doing it — and I saw you."

"You don't know me."

"I'd seen photographs. She had one on her phone case." He says it apologetically, like it's an intrusion to have known that. "You were sitting in your car in the car park at ten at night, in December, in the dark. Not crying. Not doing anything. Just sitting."

I say nothing.

"And I thought: that's the sister who doesn't sleep, and she is not okay, and somebody should—" He stops. Restarts. "And then I drove home, because that's what you do. You think *somebody should* and then you go home."

"But you didn't go home."

"I went home for nine months," he says. "Then in September I saw you again."

"Where?"

He puts the mug down.

"On the Kesselwood road," he says. "Half past two in the morning. I was driving back from a wedding I'd played at in Cranleigh. You were standing on the verge by the gate at Kesselwood Cottages, about four hundred metres before the bend, in your dressing gown."

The kitchen is very quiet. Somewhere in the building a boiler fires.

"That's not true," I say.

"I stopped the car about thirty metres past you and I sat there for a minute working out what to do, and by the time I'd decided to get out you'd started walking back toward a car parked in the layby. Your car. And you got in and you drove off, and you drove *well*, and I followed you for eleven miles because I couldn't think what else to do, and you drove home and parked and let yourself in." He looks at

me steadily. "And the next day I saw you on the stairs at the shop on Holloway and you looked straight at me and there was nothing there. Not embarrassment. Nothing. You didn't know me and you didn't know you'd been on that road."

I sit down. I hadn't been sitting.

"I didn't know what to do with it," he says. "There's no — who do you call? *Hello, I think a woman I don't know is sleepwalking on a B road?* They'd have said what's your relationship to her and I'd have said none, and they'd have said right, sir."

"So you moved into her building."

"So I moved into the flat downstairs when it came up," he says, "because I'd worked out that if it happened again I'd rather be a hundred feet away than eleven miles. And yes, I know exactly how that sounds. I've heard it in my own head every day for five months."

"Say it out loud, then. How it sounds."

He doesn't dodge.

"It sounds like a man who developed a fixation on a bereaved woman and engineered proximity to her." He holds my eyes while he says it, which costs him. "It sounds like the first four minutes of a documentary. I'm aware that if you told this to any sensible person, the sensible person would tell you to move house."

"And what would you say to the sensible person?"

"I'd say they were probably right and I'd do it again." He turns the mug. "There's no version of this where I come out of it looking like someone with good judgement. There's only the version where you were on that road at half two in the morning and somebody knew, and the version where you were on that road at half two in the morning and nobody did."

"It sounds insane."

"It is insane," he agrees. "It's also the only thing I could think of that meant somebody was awake."

I sit in his mirror-image kitchen with my hands in my lap.

"You've seen me do it since."

"Three times."

"*Three—*"

"Twenty-first of November, you went down to the bins at four in the morning and stood there for about ten minutes. Ninth of January, you got as far as the car and sat in it and came back in. And two weeks ago." He says the dates like a man

who wrote them down, which is because he is. "Two weeks ago you got in the car and I lost you at the lights on Bellhouse Row. You came back at ten past five. I know because I was on the step."

Two weeks ago.

Eleven days ago, someone logged into my dead sister's voicemail with a PIN I know without knowing, and forwarded a saved message to my phone.

"Why didn't you tell me?"

And this is the only point in the entire conversation where Adrian Cole looks away from me.

"Because the first time I tried, you'd been awake for about forty hours and you told me a story about your sister leaving your flat in a taxi at half eleven," he says. "And I'd heard that story before. Nina told me the same one."

The room tilts.

"What?"

"In November. Before she died." He looks back at me now. "She told me her sister had asked her to stop driving after drinking, and that she'd promised, and that she'd broken the promise twice and hadn't told you, and that she was frightened of what you'd say." He swallows. "And on the eleventh of December she had a lesson and she said she was going round yours at the weekend to tell you something and get it over with."

"She did come round. On the eleventh."

"Yes."

"She told me she'd done something stupid."

"Yes."

"And I said I'd help her fix it." My voice has gone strange. "I said *both, in that order.*"

Adrian says, very carefully: "Elena. On the fourteenth she went to a party and she drove there."

"I know."

"You knew then," he says. "She texted you at nine o'clock that night from the party. She told me she was going to. She said *El's going to kill me but she'd rather kill me than the alternative.*"

I sit in that kitchen.

There is no text from Nina on the fourteenth of December on my phone. I have been through that phone a thousand times. There is nothing after the eleventh.

"There's no text," I say.

"There was," he says. "She showed me the screen. She'd already sent it."

I get my phone out and I go to her thread, which I have not deleted and will not delete, and I scroll to December.

The last message from Nina is dated the eleventh. *thanks for tonight. sorry i was weird. see you at mums xx*

Then nothing. Then the twelfth, thirteenth, and on the fourteenth, at 21:04, one message.

From me.

Just: *?*

A question mark, sent by me to my sister at four minutes past nine on the night she died, in reply to nothing.

Adrian looks at the screen for a long time.

"That's an answer to something," he says quietly.

"There's nothing above it."

"No," he says. "There isn't now."

I Film Myself Sleeping

I don't sleep for two days after the corridor.

Not from fear. I want to be accurate about this, because it would be a tidier book if I'd been frightened. What I feel is something closer to professional embarrassment, which I recognise as absurd even at the time.

I have spent eleven years assessing other people's cognition. I have a laminated card in my bag with the abbreviated mental test on it. I have sat opposite families and explained, kindly, that the man they are describing is not "having a funny turn," he is exhibiting a symptom, and that symptoms are things you take to a doctor.

And here is a woman in a corridor on a closed floor for six minutes and eleven seconds, and I have told the security guard it was a smell.

On the second afternoon I get as far as the GP surgery car park.

I sit there for twenty minutes with the engine off. I have the appointment. I made it on the phone that morning, and the receptionist asked what it was regarding and I said *sleep*, which was true and which was the smallest possible true thing I could have said.

And then I think about what happens if I go in and say the rest of it.

Because I know the pathway. I *am* the pathway. You disclose parasomnia with amnesia and confusional arousal to a GP, and if you're lucky you get a sleep clinic referral in nine months. And if you're unlucky, if the GP is thorough, if they ask the right question about your driving, there is a form, and the form goes to the DVLA, and my licence is my job.

I drive home without going in.

I buy the camera that afternoon.

It's a cheap thing, a security camera meant for people who want to watch their dogs: sixty pounds, plugs into a socket, streams to an app, records to a card when it detects motion. I set it up on the bookshelf in the bedroom facing the bed and I test it by walking about, and the app shows me a small grainy grey woman walking about, and something about seeing myself in infrared makes my skin crawl in a way I decide not to examine.

Then I do everything right.

Blind down. Phone across the room. Fan on. No caffeine after two. The list from the counselling woman, all of it, including the ones I stopped doing in March because they were embarrassing.

I lie down at eleven at night, like a normal person, on a night I am not working, and I stare at the ceiling for two hours.

Somewhere after one I go under.

The app has nine clips.

I sit on the edge of the bath at half six in the morning with the phone in both hands and I watch them in order.

****01:47, 12 seconds.**** I turn over. Nothing.

****02:31, 8 seconds.**** My arm comes out from under the duvet and hangs there. Nothing.

****03:12, 4 minutes 30, the maximum clip length.****

I sit up.

Not the way a person sits up when they wake: none of the negotiation, the propping, the two false starts. I sit up in one movement, straight-backed, and I stay there.

For a minute and a half I don't move at all. My eyes are open. In infrared they're two white discs and I have to look away from the screen and then make myself look back.

Then I get out of bed and walk out of frame.

****03:17, 4 minutes 30.**** Empty room.

****03:22, 4 minutes 30.**** Empty room.

****03:26, 03:31, 03:35.**** Empty room, empty room, empty room.

I watch the empty room clips anyway. All five of them. Twenty-two minutes of an unmade bed in infrared, at half six in the morning, sitting on the edge of a bath.

I don't know what I think I'm going to see. That's not true. I do know. I think I'm going to see somebody else come into the room.

Nobody comes into the room. It's a bed with a duvet thrown back and a dent in the pillow, and a clock radio, and the corner of a wardrobe, and nothing moves for twenty-two minutes except the timestamp.

****04:02, 3 minutes 11.****

I walk back into frame. I stand at the foot of the bed. I'm holding something in my right hand that the infrared washes out into a pale rectangle.

I get into bed. I lie down. I pull the duvet up. And at 04:04:19 by the timestamp, my eyes close.

Forty-seven minutes.

The something in my right hand is on the kitchen table when I go through.

It's the notebook.

I left it in my bag, in the wardrobe, at the bottom, under a folded jumper. I put it there myself at eight o'clock last night, awake, deliberately, because I am not a stupid woman and I had a version of this thought coming.

It is on the kitchen table, open, with a biro on top of it.

There's a new entry. It's dated today.

The handwriting starts as mine and gets worse down the page, the way handwriting does when the hand is going faster than the head.

> *She's stopped sleeping properly again. She'll break. Tell her about the layby. Tell her about the layby.*

> *She won't look at the thing she's standing on.*

> *Nina asked her and she said no.*

I read it standing up in my own kitchen at ten to seven in the morning.

Nina asked her and she said no.

I don't know what that means. I want to be honest about that, here, at this exact point, because everything after this is going to make it look like I did.

I did not know what it meant.

But my hands knew something, because they were shaking so badly I had to put the notebook down on the table and step back from it.

I ring Okonjo at seven and she answers on the second ring like a woman who was already awake.

"I lied to you," I say.

"About the key."

"About the key. It opens a locker at Kesselwood Records, unit 47, and inside it there's a shoebox with my sister's house keys in it — the ones I reported missing — and a notebook I've been writing in for fourteen months that I have no memory of writing."

Silence, three seconds.

"Right," she says. "Don't touch either of them again. Where are you?"

"Home."

"Stay there. And Elena — how did you know I knew?"

"You didn't write it down," I say. "When I told you no about the key. You write everything down."

"Yeah," Okonjo says, and there's something in her voice I've never heard in it before, which is that she's tired too. "That's the trouble with talking to somebody who's good at their job. Right. I'm coming to you, and I'm bringing a colleague, and I want you to understand what that means before we're on your doorstep."

"It means I'm not a witness any more."

"It means you're not **only** a witness any more," she says. "There's a difference and it might matter later. Have you got someone who can sit with you?"

And I look through the kitchen door at the wall between my flat and the flat downstairs, where a man is doing scales, badly, on a piano at seven o'clock in the morning.

"Yes," I say. "I think I might."

The Words Mrs. Ferrante Uses

They take the notebook in a bag. They take the shoebox in another bag. The colleague Okonjo brings is called DC Wren, who is about thirty and says almost nothing and photographs my kitchen table from four angles before anyone touches anything.

Adrian sits in my living room the whole time because I asked him to and because Okonjo, after looking at him for a long moment in the hallway, said "fine."

When they've gone he says, "Do you want me to go too?"

"No."

"Okay."

He doesn't ask any questions for two hours. He makes food I eat about a third of. At some point I fall asleep on the sofa in the middle of the afternoon with the curtains open and the television on, which is the least sleep-hygienic thing a person can do, and I sleep for four hours without moving.

When I wake up he's on the floor with his back against the armchair, reading a paperback he brought from downstairs, and the light has gone orange.

"You went out," he says, without looking up.

I sit up fast. "What?"

"No — sorry. Badly put." He puts the book down. "You *were* out. Asleep. Four hours. You didn't move." He hesitates. "I watched for a bit and then I felt like a creep and read instead."

"Was I—"

"Nothing. You slept like a person."

I put my hands over my face and sit like that for a while, and he lets me.

I go back to work on the Thursday, because Denise rings and asks and because the alternative is another night in a flat where the kitchen table has been photographed from four angles.

Ridgmont at ten at night. The smell of it. The machine with its eleven moving parts.

Denise has me in the office before I start.

"Occupational health," she says, sliding a form across. "Not a punishment. It's what I'd do for anyone who'd been off with what you've been off with."

"I've been off four days."

"You've been off four days *this time*." She doesn't blink. "Elena, you've done four hundred and eleven nights in the last two years. I ran it this morning because I wanted the number before I sat down with you." She taps the desk. "Four hundred and eleven. That's not a rota, that's a person hiding."

I look at the form.

"There's something I want to say and then I'll shut up," Denise says. "When your sister died I gave you three weeks and you took eight days, and I let you come back because we were short and because you told me work was the only thing holding you together, and I believed you because it was convenient for me to believe you."

She's not looking at me now. She's looking at the wall.

"That was two years ago and I've thought about it a lot," she says. "So this time you're going to fill in the form."

I don't go to room 12.

I make it four hours. At two in the morning I'm at the desk with the tea I don't drink and I think about an eighty-two-year-old woman four hundred metres from a bend and a torch moving about in the dark, and at 02:10 I put down the pen and go.

She's awake. Of course she's awake. We keep the same hours, she and I, and always have.

"You're early," she says.

"I know."

I sit in the chair. I don't take her chart. I don't check her water. I sit in the chair with my hands in my lap and I say, "Mrs. Ferrante, I need you to tell me about the girl on the wall."

And she looks at me with the full clarity, the frightening kind, and she says: "Which time?"

The radiator ticks.

"What do you mean, which time?"

"She came twice." She says it as though it's obvious, as though I'm being slow again. "The first time she was crying and she wanted the telephone and I said the line's been off since Roberto. The second time she was cross."

"Cross with who?"

"With the other one." Mrs. Ferrante's hands are flat on the blanket, still. "The one in the car."

The corridor light hums.

"There was someone else in the car," I say.

"There were two of them, love." She frowns, not at me but at the memory, the way you frown at a thing you're holding up to the light. "They'd been shouting. Not screaming, mind. Shouting the way sisters do."

I hear myself ask it. "What did they say?"

And Mrs. Ferrante, eighty-two, dementia, a witness no lawyer would touch, says, in a completely different voice, a young voice, a mimic's voice, the voice of a woman repeating something she heard once through a hedge in the cold and has not been able to put down since:

"*Then get out. If you're that frightened of me, get out and walk.*"

The room goes away.

I know that sentence.

I don't know it from a police file, or from a coroner's report, or from anything anyone has ever told me.

I know it the way you know your own name.

"And the other one?" I say. My voice is coming from somewhere down the corridor. "What did the other one say?"

"Nothing." Mrs. Ferrante's hands start to move on the blanket. "She got out. She got out and she stood in the road, and the car went off, and she stood in the road."

"For how long?"

"A good while, love."

"How long is a good while?"

"I don't—" And now the light is going out of her, I can see it going, and I have about four seconds and I am standing over an old woman in the dark and I am asking her questions with my hands on the bed rail.

"Mrs. Ferrante. Please. What happened to the woman in the road?"

"She walked down," she says. "After the bang. She had a little torch. On her telephone."

"And then what?"

"Then she came and knocked and I didn't answer," Mrs. Ferrante says, and starts to cry. "I didn't answer. I was frightened. I'm sorry. I'm sorry, love, I didn't answer, I've said sorry every night, I'm eighty-two and I didn't answer the door."

I am holding her hand. I don't remember taking it.

"Mrs. Ferrante—"

"Roberto would have gone down," she says. "Roberto would have gone straight down."

And then her face changes, and she says, "Is Roberto back with the car?"

I stay with her while she cries, because that is the job and because I did this to her.

I want that written down plainly. I went into the room of an eighty-two-year-old woman with dementia at ten past two in the morning and I pushed her, deliberately, past the point where I could see it was distressing her, because I wanted something she had.

There is a version of me, the one who has done this job for eleven years, the one who trains new starters and tells them that a person with dementia is a person first, who would have stopped at the second question.

I did not stop at the second question. I asked eleven.

She settles eventually. She always settles; she has been settling for eighty-two years, through a war she doesn't remember and a husband she does. She asks about Roberto. I tell her about the car.

And then she takes my hand, in the dark, and says something in a small ordinary voice that is worse than any of it.

She says: "You're a good girl for coming down."

The night sister finds me eleven minutes later, sitting on the floor of the corridor outside room 12 with my back against the wall.

Her name is Angela and she has been doing this for thirty years, and she crouches down in front of me with her knees cracking and she says, "Right. Come on. Office."

"I was—"

"I know what you were doing. Priya's with her, she's settled." Angela's voice is not unkind and it is completely immovable. "Elena, love. You were in that room forty minutes and I could hear you from the stairs."

Forty minutes.

I don't have forty minutes. I have maybe six.

"I'm going to have to write it up," Angela says. "You know I am."

"I know."

"Go home. Don't drive if you're — actually, give me your keys, I'll get you a taxi."

I hand her my keys, which is how I end up standing in the Ridgemont car park at half three in the morning with no car, watching a taxi come round the roundabout, thinking about a sentence.

Then get out. If you're that frightened of me, get out and walk.

In the taxi, with the meter running and the driver saying nothing because I am obviously not a talker, I do the arithmetic I have been not doing for fourteen months.

Nina left my flat at half eleven in a taxi.

Nina had been drinking.

Nina texted me at nine o'clock, from a party, according to a man who saw the screen.

There is no text on my phone.

My phone was off from 23:52 until 06:15.

I have never once turned my phone off.

Unless.

Unless the reason there is no text on my phone is not that no text was sent.

Unless the reason is that at some point in the last fourteen months, in a room I don't remember being in, a woman with my hands went through that phone and deleted it.

Ninety-One Hours

I stop sleeping.

Not the usual thing. Not three hours in pieces. I mean I lie down and nothing happens, for four nights, and I am aware of every one of the two hundred and forty minutes in every hour of it.

By hour forty the flat has started to sound different. Fridges have a rhythm. Radiators have a voice. There is a specific frequency in the walls of that building at four in the morning that I had never noticed in six years and that I can now hear whether I want to or not.

By hour fifty-five my hands are not reliable. I drop a mug. I watch it go and my hand is still in the shape of holding it.

By hour sixty-something I write a shopping list, and look at it, and I have written *milk* four times.

Adrian comes up. He comes up more than he says he does; I know because I hear the stair, third one down, the one that goes.

Day two he brings soup.

Day three he says, "You need a doctor," and I say "I have one," and he says "when did you last see them," and I say something that isn't an answer, and he lets it go, which he shouldn't, and which I am grateful for and angry about at the same time.

On the third afternoon I ring Denise and resign.

I don't plan it. I ring to say I need more time and what comes out is *I'm handing in my notice*, and Denise says "Elena, no, don't do this on a Wednesday," which is one of the wisest things anybody says to me in the whole of that year, and I say it's already done.

The reason is not the suspension. The reason is that on the fourth of the four nights I could not remember, standing in my kitchen, whether I had given Mr. Osei his eight o'clock or only thought about giving it.

I hadn't been at work. I hadn't been at work in six days. It didn't matter: for about ninety seconds I could not establish it, and I stood there with a glass in my hand doing the arithmetic, and the thing that frightened me was not the confusion.

It was how calm I was while I did it.

An hour later I sent the email. Eleven years. Two paragraphs.

Day four he sits on the arm of my sofa at four in the afternoon in the dark with the blind down and says, "I'm going to say the thing now."

"Don't."

"You've been awake since Thursday."

"I'm fine."

"You called me Nina this morning."

The fridge does its rhythm.

"No I didn't," I say.

"You did. You came to the door and you said *Nina, is it raining,* and then you went and got a coat." His voice is very steady and it is costing him something to keep it that way. "And I said yes. Because I didn't know what else to do."

Here is what happens to a mind at ninety-one hours, and I'm setting it down because I have the notes and because if I don't write it down I'll do it again and not know I've done it.

Time stops being a line and becomes a set of rooms. You're in one, then you're in another, and the door between them is not something you experience.

Faces are fine. Faces are the last thing to go. But the *space* around faces goes strange, so that Adrian sitting on the arm of my sofa is entirely Adrian and also floating slightly forward of where the sofa is.

You get the small dark shapes at the edge. I had them in November for five days and they went away. They come back on the second afternoon and this time they don't go, and by day four one of them has resolved, in the corner by the bookshelf, into something with an outline.

I know what it is. That's the thing I want to be very clear about. I know it is a hypnagogic hallucination produced by a brain that has been denied REM for ninety-one hours and is now taking it wherever it can get it, including while my eyes are

open. I have a nursing qualification. I have read the literature. I could give you the mechanism.

And I still turn my head away from the corner by the bookshelf, because knowing what a thing is does not stop you from having to be in a room with it.

Somewhere in the third night I go looking for the list.

Groceries. Forty-one items. The things that didn't sit right.

It isn't there. Not deleted-and-recoverable, not in the archive. The note is gone, and the app tells me in its cheerful way that it was last edited eleven days ago, and eleven days ago is the night the voicemail arrived.

I stand in the kitchen at four in the morning and I understand that some version of me has closed the file.

Not hidden it. Closed it. The way you close a case: this is finished, there is nothing further to investigate, thank you for your time.

And I sit down on the kitchen floor with my back against the cupboard, and I say out loud, to an empty flat, in a voice that comes out much smaller than I intend:

"I don't want to know."

It's the first completely honest sentence I have said in fourteen months and there is nobody in the room to hear it.

At some point on the fourth night I am standing in the kitchen and the notebook is on the table.

The notebook is in a police evidence bag in a building on the other side of the city.

I stand in my kitchen at, I don't know, the clock has stopped meaning anything, let's say some hour, and I look at a spiral-bound A5 notebook that is not there, and I think, quite calmly: right. This is the bit where I go to hospital.

And then I pick it up.

It has weight. That's what I can't get past, afterwards, in the daylight, when I'm trying to explain it to a doctor who is being very patient. It had weight. My hand closed on something with a spine and corners and my arm took the load.

I open it. The pages are blank.

Every page.

And I stand there with a blank notebook that isn't there, and I hear myself say, out loud, in my kitchen, to nobody:

"I know. I know. I'll go."

I come back to myself in the car.

Engine running. Handbrake on. Wipers going against nothing, because it isn't raining, it's four something in the morning and the road is dry.

I am parked in the layby three hundred metres before the Kesselwood bend.

My hands are on the wheel at ten and two. I'm wearing my coat over pyjamas and one shoe.

The dashboard clock says 04:41.

And there is a woman standing on the verge about thirty feet ahead of the car, in the wash of the headlights, with her back to me.

She has my hair, tied the way I tie it.

I don't move. I don't blink. I sit with my hands at ten and two and I look at her, and she does not turn around, and I say, and I hear my own voice, thin and reasonable in the closed car, I say:

"I'm not doing this. You're not there."

And the woman on the verge lifts her right hand, without turning, and points down the road toward the bend.

I look where she's pointing.

There's nothing there. Wet tarmac, the crash barrier they replaced in January of last year, the gap where the road drops away toward the river.

When I look back at the verge the woman is gone, and my headlights are lighting up an empty stretch of grass and a fence post, and I am sitting in a car in a layby with the engine running at twenty to five in the morning wearing one shoe.

I put the car in gear.

And instead of driving home, I drive the three hundred metres to the bend, and I stop on the verge with the hazards on, *click, click, click,* one beat a second, the sound under eleven seconds of nothing, and I get out.

The Tabulation

I stand on the verge at the Kesselwood bend for a long time.

There is nothing to find. There was never going to be anything to find; it has been fourteen months and two winters and a resurfacing. The barrier is new. The grass has grown back over whatever the grass grew back over.

I stand where the notebook says *no glass here, why*, and I look at the road, and the sky starts doing the grey thing.

Then I drive home, badly, at thirty, with the window down for the cold.

I sleep four hours in my own bed with my shoes off and my coat on, and I dream about nothing at all, which is its own kind of mercy.

When I wake up there is a text from Adrian that says *saw the car back at 5. not asking. here if.*

Nine words. I read them about six times.

Here is a thing I have not said, because it has taken me until now to work out how to say it: at every point in this, from the parcel on the doorstep onwards, Adrian Cole gave me an exit.

That's a no said politely, and I respect it. *If it's that, we stop.* *Not asking.*

I have spent four months treating that as a technique: the patience of a man managing me. And lying on a bed at eight in the morning in a coat, it occurs to me for the first time that it might simply be what it looks like, which is a person being careful with someone.

I have got very bad at telling the difference. That's what fourteen months of this does: everybody's kindness starts to look like a move.

Okonjo calls at nine.

"Where are you?"

"Home."

"Stay. I'm ten minutes out." A pause. "Elena, is there someone with you?"

"Why does everybody keep asking me that?"

"Because I've got the phone data back," she says, "and I'd like there to be someone with you."

She spreads it on my kitchen table. Paper, actual paper, because she says she thinks better on paper and because I think she has worked out that a screen is not a good idea for me at the moment.

"This is your handset, fourteenth of December. Cell site data — which towers your phone was talking to, and when. It's not GPS. It's rough. It tells me the area, not the address."

"Okay."

"23:41. You're in the Holloway cell. That's home." Her finger moves. "23:52. Phone powers off."

"I don't turn my—"

"I know what you say," she says, not unkindly. "Let me get through it and then we'll deal with what it means."

"23:52 off. Nothing at all until 06:15, when it comes back on in the Holloway cell again. Home to home, six hours and twenty-three minutes of nothing."

"So it proves nothing. It's off."

"That's what everybody thought for fourteen months, yes." She turns the page over. "This is the other thing I asked for, and it took a long time and a favour, and it's the reason I'm sitting in your kitchen."

"There's a second handset. Pay-as-you-go, bought in cash from a shop in Cranleigh in November of the year before last. It's got eleven numbers in its call history in its entire life. Yours is one of them."

I stare at the page.

"That night," Okonjo says, "that second handset is in the Holloway cell until 23:58. Then it moves. Bellhouse cell at 00:09. Kesselwood cell at 00:24. It stays in the Kesselwood cell until 01:31, and then it comes back — Bellhouse 01:52, Holloway 02:11."

The kitchen is very quiet. Adrian, in the doorway, has not moved.

"At 00:31," she says, "your sister called your number. It went to voicemail because your phone was off. Thirty seconds after that call ends, the second handset receives a call from your sister's phone. It's answered. It lasts four minutes and eleven seconds."

I put both hands flat on the table.

"Whose phone is it?" I say.

"It was bought with cash. There's no contract, no name." Okonjo watches me. "But it was topped up twice at the same shop, and the shop has one camera, and it keeps its footage for thirty days, so that's gone. And it stopped being used on the fifteenth of December and it's never been used again."

"Then it could be anybody's."

"It could." She takes a breath. "Except that on the third of March last year, that same handset number was written down in the back of a notebook. In your handwriting."

I don't say anything.

"It's on page nineteen," she says. "There's a phone number, and under it, three words."

"What three words?"

Okonjo looks at me for a long moment. Then she takes out her phone and finds a photograph and turns it round.

Page nineteen. My handwriting. A mobile number.

And underneath, in the leftward slant I have had since school:

****the phone I bought****

I have to go and be sick, and I do that, and I come back and sit down and Adrian has put a glass of water in front of me and Okonjo has not moved an inch.

"Elena," she says. "I want to say some things, and then I want you to go to a hospital today, and I've already made a call, and there's a bed."

"Say them."

"One. Nothing on this table proves what you think it proves." She flattens her hand on the paper. "It proves a phone you bought was on that road while your sister was on that road, and that she rang it and someone answered. It does not tell me who was holding it."

"Who else would be holding it?"

"That is not my question to answer today, and it's certainly not yours." Her voice is very level. "Two. You have been awake for four days and you drove to that bend this morning."

I look up sharply.

"There's a camera on the industrial estate that catches the layby," she says. "I've had eyes on that road since Tuesday. Yes."

"You've been watching me."

"I've been watching the road." She holds my gaze. "Three. And this is the one I need you to hear properly, because it's the only thing I've got that's any use to you."

"For fourteen months you've told everyone you were at home that night. And the version of you that writes in that notebook doesn't agree, and hasn't agreed since about the seventeenth of January last year, and has been going back to that road twice a month trying to make you look at it." She taps the page. "That's not somebody handling you, Elena. Nobody's been feeding you. There isn't a person out there doing this."

"Then what is it?"

"It's you," Okonjo says, "trying to tell you something you can't hear while you're awake."

I sit with my hands flat on a table covered in paper that describes six hours of my own life that I cannot account for.

"I want to ask you something," I say, "and I want the police answer, not the kind one."

"Go on."

"If it turns out I was there. On that road. If that's what this is." I make myself finish it. "What happens to me?"

Okonjo does not soften it, which is the only reason I can hear it.

"Depends entirely on what you did. Being on a road isn't an offence. Being a passenger isn't an offence. Failing to report a collision can be, in some circumstances." She counts it off evenly. "Perverting the course of justice would be, if you'd lied to us in a statement — and you've never given a statement, which is a piece of luck I don't think you engineered."

"And if I stood there and didn't call anyone?"

The question sits in the middle of the table.

"There's no general offence of failing to help," she says. "Not in this country. Morally people find that unbearable and legally it's the position." A pause. "If a

court ever heard about a woman who did that, what they'd hear about first is the fourteen months afterwards. Judges are not stupid about grief. Neither am I."

"You're being kind."

"I'm being accurate," she says. "You'll notice I haven't said *it wasn't your fault*, and I'm not going to, because I don't know, and because you'd stop listening to me the second I did."

Ward 4

They keep me eleven days.

It isn't what people imagine. There's no dramatic admission, no restraint, nobody says *sectioned*. I go in voluntarily on the Friday afternoon with a bag Adrian packs badly, and a consultant called Dr. Iyer takes a history for two hours and asks me, at the end of it, the only question anybody has asked me correctly in fourteen months:

"When did you decide you weren't allowed to sleep?"

I say: "That's not how insomnia works."

And she says: "That's how some insomnia works."

They put me on a sleep schedule that is enforced by nurses, which is a strange thing to be on the receiving end of when you are one. Lights out at eleven. Woken at seven whether or not anything happened in between. Nothing after two. No naps.

The first three nights are bad in the ordinary way.

The ward is eleven beds and a corridor with a window at the end that looks at a car park, and I am the only person on it who has ever worked in a building like it, which turns out to matter more than I expect.

I know the rhythm. I know that the eight o'clock obs are late because the handover overran. I know why the drugs trolley stops at bed four for six minutes. I catch myself, on the second morning, standing up to help a woman called Jackie who has dropped her cardigan, and a nurse says "sit down, love, I've got it," and I sit down, and something in me falls over.

Being on the wrong side of it is not humbling. That's the word people use and it's wrong. It's **disorienting**, like hearing your own voice on a recording. All the same sounds, arranged for somebody else.

Jackie is sixty-one and has been here five weeks and tells me on the first day, without being asked, exactly what she's in for, in the flat manner of someone who has stopped finding it interesting.

"Are you going to tell me yours?" she says.

"No."

"Fair enough." She goes back to her puzzle book. "You will by Thursday."

I tell her on the Wednesday.

On the fourth night I sleep six hours and wake up and cry for forty minutes in a bathroom with a plastic mirror, and a healthcare assistant called Marcus sits outside the door and says nothing and does not go away.

On the fifth day they let me walk in the garden, which is a rectangle of grass with a bench and a smoking area that everybody uses including the people who don't smoke, because it is the only place on the ward where you can have a conversation nobody writes down.

Jackie comes out with me and rolls a cigarette she doesn't light.

"Can I tell you the thing I've worked out in five weeks?" she says.

"Go on."

"Everybody in there is in for the same thing." She gestures at the building with the unlit roll-up. "Different names on the notes. Same thing underneath. Every single one of us is in here because there's something we can't say."

"That's a bit neat."

"It's completely neat and I don't care." She puts the cigarette behind her ear. "Mine's that I hated my mother. Twenty years of caring for her, wiping her, doing everything, and I hated her the entire time, and she died and I couldn't say it, and eventually I stopped being able to leave the house." She says it without drama, the way you'd list ingredients. "Six weeks of tablets and a woman called Deborah and all I actually needed was to say the sentence in a room with a person in it."

"And that worked?"

"Christ, no. I said it and I felt worse for a fortnight." Jackie laughs. "But then it was **out**, and once it's out you can look at it, and it turns out I hated her and loved her, which apparently is allowed, and nobody had ever told me that."

On the sixth day Dr. Iyer says the word.

"Dissociative amnesia."

"That's a soap opera diagnosis."

"It's an unfashionable one," she agrees. "It also has a hundred and thirty years of case literature and I've seen eleven of them." She puts her pen down. "Elena, you're a clinician. Tell me what parasomnia needs to happen."

"Sleep deprivation. Non-REM instability. Sometimes alcohol, sometimes medication."

"And what does dissociative amnesia need?"

I don't answer.

"It needs an event," she says. "One a person cannot hold. And what I think happened to you — and I want to be careful here, because I have known you six days and I could be wrong — is that both are true. That there is something you can't hold. And that not sleeping is how you've stopped yourself from being alone with it, for fourteen months, at enormous cost."

"You think if I sleep I'll remember."

"I think you already remember," Dr. Iyer says. "I think you remember constantly, at about four in the morning, and then you drive home and put the kettle on."

My mother comes on the Saturday.

She has not been inside a hospital since the mortuary, and I know what it costs her to walk down that corridor, and neither of us says so.

She brings grapes, because that is what her generation brings, and a cardigan of mine she has washed and which I did not know she had.

We sit in the day room with the terrible chairs.

"They're looking after you?"

"They are."

"Good." She smooths her skirt. "Your uncle rang. I told him you'd got a chest thing."

"Mum."

"Well, what would you have me tell him?" It comes out sharper than she means and she hears it and stops. "Sorry."

We sit.

"I've been thinking about your father," she says, which is not a sentence I have heard from her since about 2009.

"Right."

"When he went, you did the same thing." She's looking at the window, not at me. "Fourteen years old. You did the shopping and you did the forms and you were very useful, and I let you, because I couldn't do any of it and it was such a relief that somebody could." Her hands are still on her lap. "And I remember thinking at the time: she'll pay for this later."

"And then I never thought about it again for twenty years."

I don't say anything, because there isn't anything, and because my throat has closed.

"So," my mother says, and pats my knee twice, briskly, which in our family is roughly equivalent to an hour of weeping. "That's what I've been thinking about. Eat the grapes."

Adrian comes on the Sunday. He brings a book I don't want and a bag of the specific pears I like, which he has no way of knowing and which I don't ask about.

We sit in the day room with the terrible chairs.

"They've been through the notebook properly," he says. "Ruth came round. She wanted you told in person but they wouldn't let her up, so — she asked me. I said I'd get it right."

"Say it."

"Sixty-one entries. Fifty-eight of them are you working out what happened, over and over, from the outside. Like someone doing a puzzle." He is choosing every word. "Three of them aren't."

"Which three?"

"The ones where you're not doing the puzzle. You're just — telling yourself." He gets out his phone, and he doesn't show me the screen, he reads it aloud, which I understand later was also a decision. "Twenty-eighth of April. *You said no and she died. Say it in the morning.*"

The day room hums.

"There's another one, ninth of August. *If you tell them you'll have to say the sentence. You can't say the sentence.*"

"And the third?"

"The third's the last page. You've seen it." He puts the phone away. "*Nina asked her and she said no.*"

I look at my hands.

"They mean the same thing," I say. "All three."

"Yes."

"She asked me something and I said no."

"Yes."

"And I can't hold what it was."

Adrian doesn't answer that, because it isn't a question and because he is not a man who fills silences.

After a while he says, "Ruth wanted me to tell you one more thing and I've been sitting on it for twenty minutes because I don't know if it helps."

"Tell me."

"They found the taxi." He turns to face me properly. "The one that picked Nina up from yours on the eleventh — no. Sorry. The fourteenth. There's a booking on the fourteenth, 23:31, from the party at Cranleigh to Halloway Court."

The room does the chair thing.

"To *here*," I say. "To my flat."

"The driver's still on the books. Ruth spoke to him yesterday." Adrian's voice has gone very careful. "He remembers it because she paid cash and tipped him eight quid for a nine-quid fare, which he says people don't do."

"He remembers her."

"He remembers both of you," Adrian says. "He says a woman came out of the building and got in the car with her, and they drove off together, and he thought at the time — he actually said this, Ruth wrote it down — he thought at the time *that's nice, someone's going with her.*"

What I Have Always Known

It comes back on the ninth night, and it does not come back like they say it does.

Nobody's memory returns in a flash. Mine returns the way a photograph develops in a tray: you look at it and there's nothing, and you look at it and there's nothing, and then you look away and back and it has been there the whole time.

I am asleep. Then I am awake, sitting up in a hospital bed on Ward 4 at ten past three in the morning with the blue night-light on, and I know.

I don't shout. I don't ring the buzzer. I sit in the bed with my hands in my lap and I let it be true.

What comes first is not an image. It's a physical sensation, entirely specific and entirely undeniable: the weight of a car door against my left shoulder as I push it open into cold air.

That's all. That's the whole of it, for about ninety seconds: a door, my shoulder, the temperature change.

And I sit in a hospital bed and I do not chase it, because Dr. Iyer has spent six days telling me that chasing is what closes it, and for once in my life I do as I'm told.

Then the rest arrives, in no order at all, the way a room arrives when someone turns on the light.

The smell of the inside of Nina's car, which was vanilla air freshener over cigarettes she pretended she'd stopped smoking.

The specific green of the dashboard lights.

Her hands on the wheel at ten and two, which she did when she was concentrating, which she did when she was drunk.

The click of the hazards.

And my own voice, saying a word.

I sit with all of it for perhaps twenty minutes. The ward does its night sounds: a buzzer somewhere, a trolley, the low conversation of two people at the desk who think everyone is asleep.

At some point I notice I am not frightened.

I had expected terror. I had built the moment up for fourteen months as a thing that would break me, and what it actually feels like, sitting up in a hospital bed at ten past three, is the specific relief of finally putting down something heavy you had stopped noticing you were carrying.

It is the worst thing I have ever known and it is a relief. Both. At the same time. Nobody prepares you for that either.

Here is what happened on the fourteenth of December.

At nine o'clock Nina texted me from the party at Cranleigh. The text said:

El don't be like this but I've had 2 and I'm driving home in a bit. Before you type the thing, I know. I'm telling you because you asked me to tell you. x

I read it standing in my kitchen and I felt the whole of it arrive at once: the fear, and under the fear, immediately, the anger, because with me they have never been separable, and because three days earlier she had sat in my flat and asked me a question and I had made a joke of the answer.

I rang her. She didn't pick up.

I rang her four more times.

At twenty past eleven she rang me back and she was laughing, which was the worst thing she could have done, and she said, "I'm getting a taxi, all right? I'm getting a taxi to *yours*, and you can shout at me in person, and then I'll get the taxi to take me home like a good girl."

And I said fine.

And I stood at my window at half eleven and watched a taxi pull up, and I put on my coat and I went down, and I got in beside her, and the driver said "where to, ladies," and Nina said "her house first" and gave my address, which was the address we were sitting outside, and laughed at her own joke.

We argued from Halloway to the ring road. Not shouting. The other thing, the low steady thing sisters do.

At the ring road she leaned forward and told the driver to pull over, and paid him, and tipped him eight pounds on a nine-pound fare because she was drunk and

generous and always tipped like that, and we got out at the top of the ring road at ten to midnight in December because her car was parked there from that morning.

I want to say I didn't know she was going to drive.

I knew.

I got in the passenger seat. That is the fact I have not been able to hold for fourteen months, and I am holding it now in a hospital bed with a blue light on: I got in the passenger seat of my drunk sister's car and I let her start the engine, because the alternative was a fight in a lay-by at midnight and because some part of me thought that if I was in the car I could make it be all right.

We got as far as Kesselwood Cottages.

I want to put down what was actually said in the car, because for fourteen months the thing I could not hold was not the crash. It was this.

She said: "You've been waiting for this."

I said: "That's not fair."

She said: "You've been waiting two years for me to do something you could be right about."

And I said, and this is mine, this is the one I own, this is not the sentence an eighty-two-year-old woman heard through a hedge but the one that came before it.

I said: "I'd rather be right than go to your funeral."

Twelve words. In a car, at midnight, doing fifty, to a woman who had been crying since the ring road.

By then the argument had turned. She was crying and driving, which is worse than either. I said pull over. She pulled over hard, on the verge by the hedge, and put the hazards on.

Click, click, click.

And she said: "You've been sitting there for four miles doing the face. Say it."

And I said: "You'll kill someone."

And she said: "I've had two glasses of wine."

And I said: "You've had more than two and you're crying and you can't see and I want you to get out and I'll ring someone."

And she said, and here it is, the sentence, the one an eighty-two-year-old woman heard through a hedge and could not put down, the one I have known every second of every day for fourteen months without once being able to say it out loud:

"Then get out. If you're that frightened of me, get out and walk."

And I said: "Fine."

And I got out.

I stood on the verge in the cold and slammed the door hard enough to hurt my hand, and she sat there for a moment with the hazards going, and then she pulled off the verge and drove away and I watched her tail lights go round the bend.

Eleven seconds later she rang my phone. That's the voicemail. Eleven seconds of a car with its hazards still going and a woman saying *Elena* into a phone that was ringing out on a verge four hundred metres behind her.

Except my phone wasn't on the verge.

At 23:52, standing in the taxi with my sister laughing beside me, I had turned my phone off. Because my mother had rung twice about Christmas and I hadn't wanted the interruption while I was busy being right.

So she called the other one. The pay-as-you-go, in my coat pocket, bought in cash in Cranleigh in November, bought because in November she had promised me she'd stop and I had not believed her, and I had wanted a number she wouldn't recognise, so that if she wouldn't answer to me she might answer to a stranger. That's what it was for. That is the whole shabby, loving, useless reason it existed.

She rang it at 00:31 and I answered it, standing on the verge, and we spoke for four minutes and eleven seconds.

I don't have those four minutes. Not yet. Maybe not ever.

But I know how they ended, because at 00:42 there was a sound from round the bend like nothing on the television, and then nothing at all, which is worse.

And I walked down. With the torch on my phone, the other phone, the one nobody knew about. And I stood at the barrier, and I looked down at the car in the dark and the water, and I did not go down the bank, and I did not ring 999.

I stood there for a while.

People will want to know why, and I have had two years and a great deal of professional help, and the honest answer is in three parts and none of them is good enough.

The first is that I could see the roof of the car and the angle of it and the way the water was moving around it, and I have been a nurse for eleven years and I knew. Not hoped. Knew.

The second is that the bank was steep and wet and dark and I was alone, and there is a calculation you are taught in every first-aid course ever written which is *do not become the second casualty*, and I have taught that calculation to other

people, and I performed it, correctly, in about four seconds, standing at a barrier looking at my sister's car.

The third is the one I could not hold.

The third is that in the moment I stood at that barrier, some part of me, small, fast, and entirely real, was aware that if I called 999 I would have to say who I was and where I had been and why I had got out of the car.

I want to be exact, because being exact is all I have. I do not think I decided not to call in order to protect myself. It was not that clean, and I would almost prefer it if it had been.

I think I stood at a barrier in the dark and became, for about eleven minutes, a person who could not act, because acting in any direction meant saying the sentence out loud.

She asked me to stay in the car and I got out.

Then I walked back up the road and knocked on the door of a cottage where an old woman was too frightened to answer.

And then I walked home. Eleven miles. In December.

And at 06:15 I turned my phone back on in my own flat, and at ten past one. No. That's wrong. That's the version. My mother rang at ten past one and I was on the Kesselwood road.

My mother rang at ten past one and it went to a phone that was switched off on my kitchen table.

She left a message. I have never listened to it.

I listened to it in a hospital bed at half three in the morning on the ninth night, on Ward 4, with the volume as low as it goes.

It says: *Elena, love, it's Mum. Where are you? Ring me back. Please ring me back.*

The Thing Adrian Was Protecting

Okonjo comes to the ward.

I tell her all of it, in order, in a small room with two chairs and a box of tissues nobody touches, and she records it with my consent and she does not interrupt once in fifty minutes.

When I finish she turns the recorder off.

"Right," she says. "Now I'm going to tell you what that is, legally, because you've spent fourteen months building a gallows and I'd rather you knew what's actually on the paperwork."

"Go on."

"You were a passenger in a vehicle driven by a person over the limit. That's not an offence for the passenger. You got out. You had an argument. She drove off. That's not an offence." She counts them off, flat, unsentimental. "You failed to report a collision you witnessed. That's the one. Failing to stop doesn't apply — you weren't driving — but there's a duty in some circumstances and there's obstruction if you'd lied, and you didn't lie to us, you never gave a statement at all because nobody ever asked you the right question."

"I told you I was at home."

"You told me you were at home *that night*, and I asked you about eleven thirty, and you answered about eleven thirty, and I never once asked you about half past twelve." She lets that sit. "That's on me as much as you. I had thirty-one minutes I couldn't explain and I stopped chasing them because a coroner had already said accident."

"She might have lived. If I'd called."

Okonjo doesn't rush to reassure me, which is the only reason I believe what she says next.

"I asked the pathologist that this morning, because I knew you'd ask me and I wanted a real answer and not a kind one." She takes a breath. "The injuries were not survivable. It wasn't the water and it wasn't time. If you'd been standing at that barrier with a paramedic beside you it would have made no difference at all."

I put my hands over my face.

"That's not absolution," she says. "It's information. You'll do what you want with it."

I sit with my hands in my lap in a small room with a box of tissues nobody has touched.

"I keep waiting for you to be different with me," I say.

"Different how?"

"Colder. Now that you know." I look up. "I told you I stood at a barrier and watched and did nothing. You've written it down. And you're sitting there the same as you sat there in February when you thought I was a tired woman looking for a door."

Okonjo takes a moment.

"Do you want the professional answer or the other one?"

"The other one."

"I've been doing this twenty-six years," she says. "In that time I have met perhaps nine people who did something genuinely cruel. Nine. Everybody else was frightened, or drunk, or twenty-two, or standing somewhere they couldn't cope with being." She puts her pen down. "You stood at a barrier for eleven minutes. I've met a man who drove home from a hit-and-run and had his tea. You are not in the same category as that man, and I've been at this long enough to know the difference at a glance, and I'd rather say so out loud than let you sit there constructing a version of me that's disgusted with you."

I look at the tissues.

"I'd built one," I admit.

"Course you had," she says. "You've been building one of everybody for two years."

Adrian on the Tuesday. Last visit before I'm discharged.

"I need to ask you about September," I say.

"Okay."

"You said you followed me eleven miles and I didn't know you. But the notebook has you in it from April." I've thought about this for two days. "*A. was there. Not at it. After.* That's April. You weren't in my life in April."

He looks at the floor for a while.

"No," he says. "I was in hers."

"Say it properly."

"Nina and I were seeing each other." He says it like a man putting down something he has carried up a hill. "From about the March before she died until she died. Nine months."

I look at the day room carpet, which is the colour of nothing.

"Nine months," I say.

"Yes."

"I spoke to her probably three hundred times in those nine months."

"I know."

"We went to Whitby in August. We spent four days in a caravan. She was on her phone constantly and I took the piss out of her for it and she said it was work." I hear my own voice doing something unpleasant. "It was you."

"It was me."

"Did she—" I stop, and make myself ask the real one. "Did she say why she wasn't telling me?"

Adrian is quiet for a moment.

"She said you'd be disappointed in her," he says. "Not angry. Disappointed. She said anger she could work with and disappointment was the other thing." He turns his hands over. "And she said — and I've thought about whether to tell you this for four months — she said *El thinks I'm the one who gets away with things.*"

The room hums.

"She wasn't wrong," I say.

"No," says Adrian. "She wasn't."

The day room hums.

"She was thirty," I say. "You were—"

"Thirty-nine. And her guitar teacher, and married, and separating, which is a word people use when they want the credit for leaving before they've left." He doesn't dress it up, and I notice he doesn't. "It was a mess and it was mine as much as hers. She wanted to tell you. She'd wanted to tell you since about July."

"*The stupid thing.*"

"The stupid thing." He nods. "On the eleventh she came to your flat to tell you about me and lost her nerve and asked you a hypothetical instead. She rang me from the taxi afterwards. She was furious with herself."

I think about my sister sitting on my sofa with a glass in both hands saying *would you help me fix it, or would you tell me it was stupid first.*

I think about me saying *both, in that order, obviously,* and being pleased with myself.

"And after," I say. "*A. was there. Not at it. After.*"

"I went to the road," he says. "About a week after the funeral. I sat in the lay-by for a couple of hours because I couldn't go to the grave — I had no standing to go to the grave, I was a man nobody knew about — and the lay-by was the only place I could think of that was hers." He rubs his face. "And you were there. Standing on the verge in a dressing gown at two in the morning. That was the first time. Not September. December."

"You've known for fourteen months."

"I've known there was a woman who went and stood on that road at night, yes."

"You could have said something!"

"To who?" And for the first time since I've known him his voice goes up. "To the police, that I was the dead woman's secret boyfriend and I'd been watching her sister at night? To *you*, at a funeral I stood at the back of?" He gets hold of himself, visibly, with effort. "I've made every single choice here badly, Elena. I know that. I moved into your building. I'm aware of exactly how that will read in any room I ever have to describe it in."

"Then why?"

"Because you were the last person she talked about," he says. "Because I sat in a car in a lay-by and listened to her voicemail greeting for a month, and the one thing I could actually do for her was be a hundred feet from her sister."

We sit in the terrible chairs.

"Ruth knows about the two of you now," I say. It isn't a question.

"I told her on Thursday. Before you remembered anything. She was — " he makes a small sound that isn't a laugh, "she was extremely unimpressed with me, and she wrote it all down, and she said the phrase *you should have come forward in December of last year, Mr. Cole,* and she's right."

"Are you in trouble?"

"No," he says. "I'm just a man who behaved like an idiot in a way that isn't illegal. That's most people, most of the time."

There's one more thing, and I make myself do it before they discharge me.

I ring my mother.

She answers on the fourth ring, and she says "Elena?" in the specific voice she has used since December of the year before last, the one with the flinch built into it.

And I say: "Mum. I need to tell you where I was that night."

There is a silence on the line of a particular length.

"Right," my mother says. "Hang on. I'm going to sit down."

I hear her sit down. I hear the chair in the hall, the one nobody sits in, the one by the telephone table that has been there since 1994.

"Go on then," she says.

And I tell her. All of it, in order, in a day room with terrible chairs, while a man two hundred miles into his own guilt waits in the car park because I asked him to.

It takes eleven minutes.

When I finish, my mother is quiet for long enough that I check the screen to see if the call has dropped.

Then she says: "Was she frightened?"

Of all the questions.

"I don't know," I say. "I don't have the last four minutes. I don't think I ever will."

"No," my mother says. "Well."

Another silence.

"I knew she'd been drinking," she says. "The police told me at the time and I've never said it out loud to a single person, not to you, not to your uncle, not to anybody at the funeral. Two years." Her voice does not break; my mother's voice does not break, it just gets very flat, which is worse. "I've let people think it was the road."

"Mum—"

"So there's two of us, then," she says. "Sitting on it."

Sixty-One Entries

They discharge me on a Thursday with a bag of medication I will take for four months and a follow-up in three weeks and a sheet of paper about sleep that I could have written myself.

Dr. Iyer says, at the door: "The amnesia will not come back. That's not a promise, it's a probability, and it's a high one. What comes back is the wanting to not know. That's the thing to watch."

"How do I watch it?"

"You'll know," she says. "It'll feel like being busy."

Okonjo gives me the notebook back in June.

It has been through a lab and a solicitor and a conversation I wasn't in, and in the end it is not evidence of anything, because there is no case: the coroner's finding stands, the death was accidental, and a woman writing about her sister in the night is not a crime.

"There's no proceedings," she says. "There's a letter for the file about the failure to report, and there won't even be that if I write it the way I intend to write it, which I'm telling you so that you don't spend a year waiting for a knock."

"I'd have taken the knock."

"I know," she says. "That's rather the problem with you."

We're in a café near the station, not her office, which I understand is deliberate.

"Can I ask you something," I say. "How long did you know?"

"Know is a strong word."

"How long did you *think*?"

She turns her cup a quarter turn on the saucer, the thing she does.

"From the second time I interviewed you, fourteen months ago." She meets my eyes. "You told me the taxi came at half eleven and she went home. And I said *and then what did you do*, and you said *I washed up*, and I asked what you washed up, and you said two bowls and two glasses."

"That's true. I did."

"You washed up two glasses at midnight and you were completely certain about it fourteen months later," Okonjo says. "People who go to bed don't remember the washing up. People who need to be somewhere they weren't do." She shrugs. "It's not evidence. It's not even suspicion. It's a thing you notice and file, and I filed it, and then a coroner said accident and I closed the file with the thing still in it. That's the whole job, most days. Filing things you don't get to use."

"Then why did you keep taking my calls?"

"Because you kept ringing," she says. "And in twenty-six years I have never once had a person work that hard to open a case that would only ever hurt them."

She finishes her tea.

"There's a thing I've been going to say to you for a month and I keep not saying it, so I'll say it now while I've still got the warrant card." She sets the cup down. "You're going to spend the next few years deciding what kind of story this was. Everybody does. And there are two on offer.

"One is: a woman got out of a car in temper and her sister died and she hid it for fourteen months.

"The other is: a woman who could not remember something spent fourteen months, at four in the morning, in the cold, driving to the place it happened and writing it down, until she made herself find out. At enormous cost. When absolutely nobody was making her."

I look at her.

"Both of those are accurate," Okonjo says. "I've read the file. They're the same set of facts. You'll pick one and you'll live inside it, and I'd like to be on record as having told you that the second one is also true, because in about eighteen months you'll have forgotten anybody ever said it."

There is one thing in the notebook that Okonjo asks me about directly, in the café, before she hands it over.

"Page fifty-three," she says. "I need to ask, and then I'll never ask again."

I know the page. Everybody who has read the notebook knows the page.

It's from the twelfth of November, three months before it all came apart, and it says:

> *If I can't get there by December I'll do the other thing. I've thought about the other thing enough now that it's not frightening, which is how you know.*

"Were you planning to kill yourself?" Okonjo says.

The café does its noise around us.

"I don't know," I say. "That's the honest answer and I've had it out with Priti four times. I don't remember writing it. I don't remember thinking it." I turn the cup. "But I read it and I don't feel like it belongs to a stranger, which is the bit that frightens me."

"Have you told your doctor?"

"Day two on the ward. It's in my notes. There's a plan and there's a number and I've used it once."

Okonjo nods slowly.

"Good," she says, and that's all, and she never asks again, and I find out about eleven months later, from a nurse on a completely unrelated ward, of all places, that she rang Dr. Iyer's team the day she read it, before she ever raised it with me.

I read the notebook properly in July, on a bench outside the flat, in daylight, with a coffee, like a person reading a book.

Sixty-one entries, fourteen months. I read them in order and it takes four hours and I stop twice.

It is not a horror object. That's what surprises me. Awake, I had been frightened of it: a thing written by a stranger with my hands.

But it isn't a stranger. It's me, obviously, patently, on every page. The same jokes. The same impatience. The same habit of writing *right* at the start of a paragraph when I'm about to make myself do something.

She, or I, spent fourteen months going back to a road twice a month in the dark, taking measurements, drawing the bend from memory, noting where the glass wasn't. Sitting in a lay-by. Standing at a gate.

Doing, in other words, exactly what I would have done in daylight if I had been able to bear it. Working the problem. It's the only way I know how to be.

The last entry, the one from eleven days before it all came apart, I read four times.

> *Found the account still open. PIN was the obvious one. There's a saved message from that night I never listened to. I'm going to send it to my phone so that she has to hear it. She won't do anything unless she has to.*

She won't do anything unless she has to.

I had read that in a record shop storeroom and heard something monstrous in it: a third person, a stranger in my own hand, talking about me.

Sitting on a bench in July I read it and hear my sister.

Not literally. I'm not going to do that to you at this stage of the book; there's no ghost, there was never a ghost, there was a woman with a torch on a phone standing at a barrier and fourteen months of not being able to say so.

But the *tone* is Nina. *She won't do anything unless she has to.* That's Nina on me, exactly, the way she said it at twenty-two when I wouldn't leave a job I hated, the way she said it at twenty-eight when I wouldn't leave a man I didn't like.

Some part of me had been keeping her voice going, and using it, and pointing it at me, because it was the only voice I'd ever listened to.

There's one entry I go back to more than the others, and it isn't one of the dramatic ones.

It's from a Tuesday in May, and it says:

> *Bought bread. Put it in the freezer. She used to say I bought bread like someone expecting a siege. Wrote this down because I laughed and there was no one in the room.*

Nineteen words about bread.

I sat on that bench in July and read that entry and cried for about ten minutes, properly, with the noise, in a public place, for the first time since the second week.

Because that's her. Not the road, not the barrier, not the eleven seconds. A woman standing in a kitchen at four in the morning laughing on her own at something her dead sister used to say about bread, and writing it down because there was nobody to tell.

Fourteen months. Sixty-one entries. And in all of them, the thing that comes off the page is not guilt.

It's how much she missed her.

I have spent two years believing that what I was carrying was a secret. It wasn't. Or it wasn't only that. Underneath the secret there was just an enormous, ordinary, unspectacular missing, which had nowhere to go because I would not let it out in

daylight, so it went out at four in the morning, in a locker in a record shop, in nineteen words about bread.

Priti asks me, in September, what I want to do with the notebook.

"That's a therapy question."

"It's a practical question. It's an object and it's in your wardrobe and you'll have to decide."

I say I'll think about it. I think about it for three weeks.

I don't burn it, which is what I assume I'll do and which I have a small ceremony half-planned for. Burning it would make it a symbol, and it isn't a symbol, it's sixty-one nights of work by a version of me who had nobody to help her.

I don't read it again either. I've read it twice and there's nothing left in it I don't have.

In the end I put it in the box with the photographs, because that's where the rest of her is, and because a woman who wrote nineteen words about bread at four in the morning belongs in the same box as a photograph of Whitby in 2003.

I put the notebook in the wardrobe, with the box of photographs I couldn't walk past in January of last year.

Then, because I have learned one thing in eleven days on Ward 4 and four months of Thursday afternoons with a woman called Priti who does not let me get away with anything, I take the box out again, and I take the photographs out of it, and I put two of them on the hall table.

One of Nina at the wedding, mid-laugh.

And one of the two of us on the beach at Whitby in 2003, curled at one corner, which had been in a shoebox in a locker in a record shop and is now in a frame in my hallway, where anyone standing at my front door can see it.

What Ruth Okonjo Was Waiting For

There is one loose end and I am the only person who can pull it, which I don't realise until August.

Mrs. Ferrante.

I have not been back to Ridgemont. I resigned in April from a hospital bed, by email, which is a cowardly way to end eleven years and which Denise answered with a kindness that made it worse.

But there is a woman in room 12 who has been apologising every night for fourteen months for not answering her door.

I ring Denise. I ask if I can visit as a visitor. There is a pause on the line of the kind that means a manager is thinking about safeguarding, and then she says: "Come on a Tuesday afternoon. I'll be on."

Room 12 in daylight is a different room. I have only ever seen it at two in the morning. There's a window I've never seen the view from: the car park, four cars, a hedge and the road.

She's in the chair, not the bed, with a blanket over her knees and the television on with the sound off.

"Mrs. Ferrante."

She looks at me and there is nothing there. Not the flicker. Nothing.

"Hello, love," she says, politely, to a stranger.

I sit down anyway.

I sit with her for forty minutes and we talk about the television and about Roberto and about a holiday in Scarborough in 1974, and she asks me twice if I've come far, and I say not far, and she says that's good.

And at the end of it, when I stand up to go, she takes my wrist.

Her hand is very light and very cold and completely certain.

"You went down, didn't you," she says.

The room is full of afternoon.

"Yes," I say. "I went down."

"I couldn't." Her eyes are wet. "I've got my hip. And I was frightened, and I've never told a soul."

"You told me."

"Did I?"

"You did. You told me and I heard you, and I've told the police, and they wrote it down, and it's on a file with your name on it." I put my other hand over hers. "You did answer, Mrs. Ferrante. It took you fourteen months and you were the only one who did."

She looks at me for a long moment.

"Is Roberto back with the car?" she says.

"He's parked out front," I say.

"Good," she says. "Good."

She dies in March, of pneumonia, which is what most of them die of in the end whatever it says on the form.

Denise rings to tell me, which she did not have to do and which I understand is a kindness aimed at both of us.

There are nine people at the funeral. Four are staff from Ridgemont on their day off. There is no family. The celebrant reads out a life in six minutes (born in Naples in 1943, came to England at nineteen, married Roberto in 1966, forty-one years at Kesselwood Cottages, no children) and gets her name wrong twice, and nobody corrects him, because there is nobody there whose job it is to.

I stand at the back like a guitar teacher.

Afterwards, in the car park, Priya finds me. She's in a black coat that doesn't fit her and she looks about nineteen.

"You left," she says. "You just — email."

"I know."

"I thought I'd done something."

That lands somewhere it will stay for a while.

"You didn't do anything," I say. "You asked me if I was all right and I lied to you, and that was mine, not yours."

She thinks about it.

"Are you all right now?"

And I stand in a crematorium car park in March and give a colleague of eleven years the first accurate answer I have given anybody in that building.

"No," I say. "But I'm being treated, and I'm sleeping, and I'll tell you the whole thing if you want it, but not here."

Priya nods slowly.

"There's a place on Farrow Street," she says. "Does coffee at hours that suit people who work nights."

Okonjo retires in September. She tells me at a pub near the station, over a lemonade, having told me at the door that she's driving and that she'd have liked a pint.

"Twenty-six years," she says. "The party's on the fourth. It'll be dreadful."

"Will you miss it?"

"I'll miss knowing things." She considers. "That's the addictive part. Nobody tells you the middle of anything ever again."

I've had a question for six months and this is the last chance I'll get to ask it.

"That first day," I say. "When I brought you the key. You gave me Ken's number for the audio, and you'd already put Nina's number back through the system before I'd asked you to."

"Mm."

"You weren't investigating a stranger who was harassing me."

"No."

"You were waiting for me to walk myself to it."

Okonjo turns her glass a quarter turn.

"If I'd sat you down in February and said *I think you were on that road and I think you can't remember,* what would have happened?"

I think about it honestly.

"I'd have stopped talking to you."

"You'd have stopped talking to me, you'd have stopped sleeping entirely, and the one person who might have got there — which was you, at four in the morning, in a notebook — would have stopped too, because you'd have been guarding it." She says it without any triumph. "There's no interview technique for a thing a person is keeping from themselves. All you can do is keep the door open and not lie to them and wait."

"That's not a technique, that's just being decent."

"That's most of the job," Okonjo says. "The rest is paperwork."

There's a hearing in August. Not a court. The nursing council, because Angela wrote it up as she said she would and because a registered nurse spending forty minutes questioning a resident with dementia at two in the morning is a thing that has to go somewhere.

I don't defend it. That surprises everybody including me.

I sit in a room with three people and a laptop and when they ask me to respond to the allegation I say: "It's accurate. I did that. She was distressed and I kept going because I wanted something from her."

The woman chairing it looks up.

"Do you want to tell us about the mitigating circumstances?"

"There are some," I say. "I'd rather they were in the notes than in my mouth."

They give me a caution and a condition: supervised practice for twelve months, and a return-to-work interview with occupational health before I take another post.

It is, by any measure, the lightest possible outcome, and I walk out into a car park in August feeling worse than when I went in, and it takes Priti about three sessions to get out of me why.

Which is: I had rather been hoping they'd strike me off.

Ken Boyd dies in the same month, which I find out from Okonjo, who finds out from a colleague, because Ken had no one to put in a phone.

Heart, in his kitchen, quickly. He was seventy-nine.

I go to that funeral too. There are more people than I expect: a lot of men in their seventies who all seem to know each other from somewhere technical, and who talk in the crematorium car park about a job in Leeds in 1994 as if it happened last year.

I introduce myself to one of them and say Ken helped me with an audio file.

"Oh, he'd have loved that," the man says. "He got bored, you know. He'd have had you in that garage for hours."

"He did."

"Good." He nods, satisfied. "Good."

The cat went to a niece in Carlisle, apparently. Duchess. Deaf as a post and eleven years old.

I think about Ken more than I expect to, over that autumn. About a man who spent thirty years cleaning up the last recorded seconds of other people's lives, and who told me straight out, at the very beginning, that he did sound and not fault, and who was the only person in the whole of it who warned me, before I'd even started, that I was about to build a house on eleven seconds.

I get a job in October. Community nursing, days, four days a week. It pays less. It has meetings in it, which I hate.

I sleep about six hours a night. Some weeks five. In February, the anniversary of the anniversary, which nobody warns you about, I have a run of four bad nights and I ring Priti and she moves my appointment up, and that's the whole crisis: I make a phone call and someone moves an appointment.

It is astonishing to me, still, that this is available to people. That it was available the whole time.

In November, Adrian asks me to have dinner with him properly, which is a thing we have both been carefully not doing for eight months.

I say: "I don't know what this is."

And he says: "Nor do I. I know what it isn't, if that helps. It isn't me making anything up to her."

"It might be me."

"It might be," he agrees. "So we go and have a bad dinner and find out. And if it's that, we stop."

We go. The dinner is fine. He talks about a student who has finally got through a piece she's been stuck on since March, and I talk about a man on my rounds with an ulcer that won't close and a dog he loves more than his own leg.

Neither of us mentions her, for two hours, and then at the end, over the bill, he says: "She'd have found this unbearable, by the way. Us. She'd have made a noise."

"She'd have made *the* noise," I say.

And we both do it, at the same time, badly: the specific noise Nina made, half a groan and half a laugh, the one she made when something was too much and she loved it.

We do it in the middle of a restaurant and the couple at the next table look over, and I laugh so hard I have to put my head down on the table, and it is the first time since the fourteenth of December of the year before last that I have laughed like that, with my whole chest, without checking myself halfway through.

Saying It Out Loud

The fourteenth of December falls on a Saturday.

Two years.

My mother organises it, which is itself remarkable, because for two years my mother has organised nothing, has answered the phone on Sundays and put it down after eleven minutes, has kept a house so tidy you could tell nobody was living in it.

She rings in November and says: "I thought we'd have people. At the house. Nothing — not a service. Just people. She'd have hated a service."

"She'd have hated people too."

"She'd have hated it and come anyway and been the loudest person there," my mother says, and there is something in her voice I haven't heard in two years, which is Nina.

I spend the week before it in a state I recognise from nursing exams: not dread exactly, but a kind of constant low hum, the body getting ready for something the mind hasn't admitted to yet.

Priti and I do two sessions instead of one.

"You're going to tell them," she says on the Tuesday. It isn't a question.

"I don't know."

"Elena."

"I don't *know*." I hate this room sometimes, and the fact that I hate it is apparently progress. "I've written it out. I've got it down to about four hundred words."

"Read it to me."

"No."

"All right." She lets it go, which she does about once a month and only when it counts. "Then tell me what you're most afraid will happen."

And I say, without thinking about it at all: "That somebody will say it's not my fault."

Priti writes something down for the first time in twenty minutes.

"Why is that the frightening one?"

"Because if it's not my fault then it's nothing," I say. "It's just a thing that happened. And she'd be dead for no reason at all, and there'd be nowhere to put any of it."

There is a silence in that room of a particular quality.

"Right," Priti says eventually. "Well. Now we know what we've actually been doing for eight months."

There are fourteen of us in a front room in Bellhouse with too many chairs.

Nina's friends from the school. Two women from university I've met three times. An uncle. My mother's neighbour who has done all the food and will not sit down.

And Adrian, who I asked, and who said "are you sure" three times and then came.

My mother knows. I told her in July, on a Sunday, in the eleven minutes.

She was quiet for a long moment and then she said: "Well. That explains the guitar," and I said what, and she said, "She bought a guitar. She was tone deaf, Elena. I've been wondering about that guitar for two years."

At some point in the afternoon it goes quiet the way rooms do, and my uncle says something about how she'd have been thirty-two, and everyone does the arithmetic they've all already done.

And I stand up.

I hadn't planned to. I want that on the record, since this is the last of it: I had not planned to.

"I need to tell you all something," I say. "And I've practised it, and I'm still going to do it badly."

Fourteen faces.

"I was in the car with her that night."

My mother's neighbour stops with a plate in her hand.

"I got in the taxi with her outside my flat at half eleven. We argued the whole way. She'd been drinking, and I knew she had, and I got into her car with her anyway because I thought if I was there I could stop it, and I couldn't." My voice is doing something and I keep going through it. "We stopped on the Kesselwood road. She told me to get out and walk if I was that frightened of her. And I said fine. And I got out and I slammed the door and I let her drive away."

Nobody says anything.

"She rang me eleven seconds later and I didn't get to the phone in time. She rang again and I answered and we talked for four minutes and I don't know what we said. And then I heard it happen from four hundred metres away, and I walked down, and I stood at the barrier, and I did not call anyone." I make myself look up. "I want you all to hear the last part properly. I did not call anyone. I walked home. Eleven miles. And in the morning I let my mother tell me my sister was dead and I said *what?* and I have let all of you believe that for two years, and the reason I could do that is that I made myself forget it, and I did such a good job of it that I believed me too."

The clock in my mother's front room ticks the way clocks in front rooms do.

"The police know. There's no case; the coroner's finding was right, it was an accident. A doctor has told me she could not have survived it and I've decided to believe her, most days." I put my hands down at my sides. "I'm not telling you this so that you'll say it's all right. I'd rather you didn't, actually. I'm telling you because I have found out what it costs to not say it, and the bill came to fourteen months of my life and nearly all the rest of it."

And then I sit down.

I have thought since about what it cost to say it in that room rather than in a police station or a consulting room, and the answer is that a police station and a consulting room are places where people are paid to hear things.

Rachel from the school is not paid to hear it. My uncle is not paid to hear it. My mother's neighbour with a plate of sandwiches in her hand is not paid to hear it, and she is going to go home tonight and tell her husband, and by Tuesday four people in Bellhouse who knew my sister will know what I did.

That's the part. Not the saying. The Tuesday.

Dr. Iyer asked me, before I was discharged, what I was most afraid of, and I said *remembering*, and she said "you already remember," and I said fine, then, being charged with something.

And she said, "I don't think that's it either."

She was right. What I was afraid of is a room in Bellhouse on a Saturday in December with fourteen people in it who loved her, finding out that the last thing I said to her was *fine*.

Here is what happens.

My uncle looks at the carpet. One of the women from university starts crying and the other one takes her hand. Nina's friend Rachel from the school says, "*Fourteen months*, Elena?" in a voice with something hard in it, and I say "yes," and she says nothing else, and that is fair, and I am glad she said it.

And my mother gets up out of her chair and crosses the room.

She has not touched me since the funeral. We are not a family that does it; we are a family that stands slightly apart and says useful things about parking.

She sits down on the arm of my chair and she puts her hand flat on the back of my neck, the way you would with a child, and she says, to the room, not to me:

"She got in the car with her."

Nobody answers.

"Everybody else in this room got a phone call," my mother says. "She got in the car. She's the only one of us who was *there*." Her hand does not move. "You can all think what you like on the way home. In this house we're going to be glad she wasn't in it at the bend."

Later, in the kitchen, doing the washing up because I need my hands to be doing something, Rachel comes in and stands beside me with a tea towel and dries for a while without speaking.

Then she says: "She'd have been so angry with you."

"I know."

"Not about the road." Rachel puts a plate down. "About the fourteen months. She'd have been livid about the fourteen months. She'd have driven to your flat and shouted at you and then made you eat something."

I laugh, which is not what I expect to do at the sink at my mother's house on the fourteenth of December.

"Yeah," I say. "She would."

Rachel picks up another plate.

"She talked about you all the time," she says. "You know that, don't you? Staff room, every Monday. *My sister the nurse.*" She dries carefully. "There was a thing in October, before — a kid in her class whose mum was in hospital, and Nina didn't know what to say to him, and she rang you at lunchtime from the corridor and asked you what happens on a ward, so she could tell him something true."

I stop with my hands in the water.

I remember that call. I was on a night rotation and asleep and I was short with her, and I told her about visiting hours and what the machines do and why they beep, and she said *thanks El* and rang off, and I went back to bed irritated.

"He's fine, by the way," Rachel says. "The kid. His mum's fine. He's in year six now and he's a nightmare."

We stand at the sink for a while.

"I didn't know she did that," I say.

"No," says Rachel. "Well. You were asleep."

The Quiet Hours

The day shift starts at eight, and by ten past I already know how the day will go.

Mrs. Advani in Bellhouse first, because her dressing needs doing before her daughter arrives and she likes to be presentable for her daughter. Then Mr. Okafor and the ulcer and the dog. Then the new one on Farrow Street, discharged Tuesday, who according to the notes is "reluctant to engage," which in my experience means frightened and rude, in that order and for good reason.

I have a car with a boot full of dressings and a folder with a list in it. There are meetings on Thursdays. I hate the meetings.

It is a completely ordinary job and I am extremely bad at being thanked for it, which Priti says is a thing we will get to eventually.

Mr. Okafor's dog is called Sandra. He tells me this on the first visit with an entirely straight face and it takes me three weeks to work out he is not joking. Sandra is fourteen and arthritic and lies across his feet while I do the dressing, and the ulcer is going to close in about four months and both of us know it and neither of us says so, because saying so is how you jinx a thing.

The new one on Farrow Street is called Mrs. Adeyemi and she is not reluctant to engage, she is furious, which is different and which the notes did not say. She is furious because she is sixty-eight and has been sent home from a hospital that did not tell her what it had found, and nobody has explained anything to her in nine days.

So I sit down at her kitchen table and I explain it. All of it, twice, with a pen and the back of an envelope.

It takes forty minutes I do not have. There are meetings about this: about "capacity" and "visit duration" and a phrase I have come to hate, which is "scope of role."

I have started, in these meetings, to say things out loud.

That's new. For eleven years at Ridgemont I was the person who did the thing properly and said nothing about the fact that the thing was impossible. Now I put my hand up and say: *this is a forty-minute job and you've costed it at fifteen, and I'd like that written in the minutes.*

It doesn't change anything. It goes in the minutes.

Priti says this is what she means by *the wanting to not know* being the thing to watch: that the opposite of it isn't confessing, it's just saying ordinary true things at ordinary volume, on Thursdays, in rooms where it's inconvenient.

I sleep.

Not perfectly. I want to say that clearly, because I've read the books where the woman remembers the thing and then sleeps like a child, and it isn't like that, and I'd have thrown one of those books across a room in the state I was in.

I sleep six hours, most nights. Some nights four. In the run-up to December it gets worse and I know now that it will get worse, which is most of the battle.

There are practical things, and nobody writes about the practical things, so I will.

I gave my car keys to Adrian for four months. Not symbolically. He kept them in his flat and I knocked on his door in the morning when I needed the car, which is humiliating for about three weeks and then becomes as ordinary as anything else.

There is a bolt on the inside of my front door, high up, at a height I have to consciously reach for. Dr. Iyer's suggestion. The theory is that a sleeping brain will do a familiar action and not an unfamiliar one, and the theory has held so far.

I do not work nights. That's permanent. It cost me eleven years of seniority and about six thousand a year, and it is not negotiable, and when the agency rings, and they always ring, they are always short, I say no in the first sentence.

Twice in the first year I woke up somewhere I didn't remember going. Once in the hall. Once in the car, on the drive, with the engine off and the keys in my lap.

Both times I went back inside and rang Priti in the morning and said the words *it happened again*, out loud, to another person, and both times the world did not end.

That's the whole technique, in the end. It's embarrassingly small. You say the thing out loud to somebody while it's still small enough to say.

I still go to the Kesselwood road.

Not at night. Not in a dressing gown, not in a car with the hazards going, not in the state I was in.

I go on the fourteenth of December, in the afternoon, in daylight, and I park in the lay-by three hundred metres before the bend and I walk down.

There's a fence post I know. There's a stretch of new barrier that has weathered now and doesn't look new. There's the gate at the cottages where an old woman stood in her dressing gown and was too frightened to answer her door, and did not forgive herself for it for the rest of her life, which ended in March of this year, and whose funeral I went to and stood at the back of like a guitar teacher.

I stand at the barrier for a while.

The council put a sign up in the spring. SLOW, BEND. It is the third sign on that stretch and it will not make any difference to anybody, and I know because I sat in a room in February and asked for it, along with a request for the barrier to be extended forty metres, which was refused on cost.

I did that properly, in daylight, with a form. It took four months and two meetings and I was polite in both of them.

The sign is not for her. I want to be clear about that with myself, standing here, because it would be very easy to let it be a headstone and it isn't one; she has a headstone, in Bellhouse, and I go there too, and it says her name and two dates and *loved*.

The sign is for whoever comes round that bend at midnight next December.

That's the only useful thing I have found to do with any of it, in the end. It is embarrassingly small, like everything else that works.

I don't talk to her. There's nothing there to talk to; I've been very consistent about that and I'm not going to lose my nerve at the end.

But I stand there, and I hold in my head the four minutes and eleven seconds I still don't have and probably never will, and the thing I have come round to, after two years and a woman called Priti and a great deal of arguing, is that the four minutes were probably not important.

I know what my sister was like. I know exactly what she'd have said, because she said it to me on a verge eleven seconds earlier and it is carved into me: *if you're that frightened of me, get out and walk.*

And I know what I'd have said back, because I said it, and because it was the last thing I ever said to her, and because for fourteen months it was the sentence I could not let myself say out loud.

I said: "Fine."

Not *please*. Not *pull over and I'll drive*. Not *I love you, you idiot, give me the keys*.

Fine.

That's it. That's the whole thing at the bottom of fourteen months of not sleeping and a notebook in a locker and a phone bought in cash and an old woman apologising every night to a door.

One word, said in the cold, out of temper, by a frightened person who wanted to win.

Priti asked me, in about the ninth month, what I thought forgiveness would look like, and I said I didn't want it, and she said she hadn't asked whether I wanted it.

I've thought about that a lot.

I don't think what happened to me was that I was forgiven. Nobody had the standing to do it: not my mother, not Ruth Okonjo, not Adrian, and certainly not me.

What happened is smaller and more useful. I stopped requiring myself to have been a better sister than I was, at midnight, in December, in a car with a woman I loved and was furious with.

I was as good a sister as I was. Which was: pretty good for thirty-four years, and then not good enough for about ninety seconds on a verge, at the exact moment it counted.

You can hold that. It turns out you can hold that, if you can say it out loud, and if somebody is in the room when you do.

On the way back to the car I stop at the gate of 8 Kesselwood Cottages.

Somebody lives there now. There's a child's scooter on its side by the step and a hanging basket that has been given up on, and the hedge has been cut back hard, and the gate is the same gate.

I stand at it for a minute.

She was eighty-two. She had a hip that wouldn't take the bank. She had no telephone because the line had been off since Roberto, and no children, and no one to tell, and she stood at this gate in a dressing gown in December and heard a thing happen four hundred metres away and could not do anything about it, and for the last fourteen months of her life she apologised for it every single night to a woman who was doing exactly the same thing.

The two of us, four hundred metres apart, both standing in the dark not answering a door.

The difference is that she was old and frightened and had no way to help, and I was thirty-four with a phone in my hand.

I've stopped trying to make that comparison come out in my favour. It doesn't. But I've also stopped needing it to, which took longer.

There's a woman in the front window of the cottage now, looking out at me with the polite alarm of somebody who has noticed a stranger at her gate.

I lift a hand. She lifts one back, uncertainly.

I go back to the car.

I drive home before it gets dark.

There's a piano going when I come up the stairs: scales, badly, because his eleven o'clock has clearly moved to a five o'clock and is no better for it.

I let myself in. The photograph of the two of us at Whitby in 2003 is on the hall table where anybody can see it, curled at one corner, in a frame that doesn't match anything.

I put the kettle on. I make the tea. I drink it, this time.

And at eleven o'clock I go to bed, and I lie down in the dark, and the flat does its noises: the fridge, the radiator, the particular frequency in the walls at that hour that I can still hear whenever I choose to listen for it.

I don't listen for it.

I close my eyes, and somewhere below me a man plays four bars of something properly, for himself, now the students have gone.

And I sleep through the quiet hours, all of them, right through to the light.

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About the Author

Digital Empire publishes psychological suspense about ordinary people in the hours nobody else is awake for. THE QUIET HOURS is the first in the series.